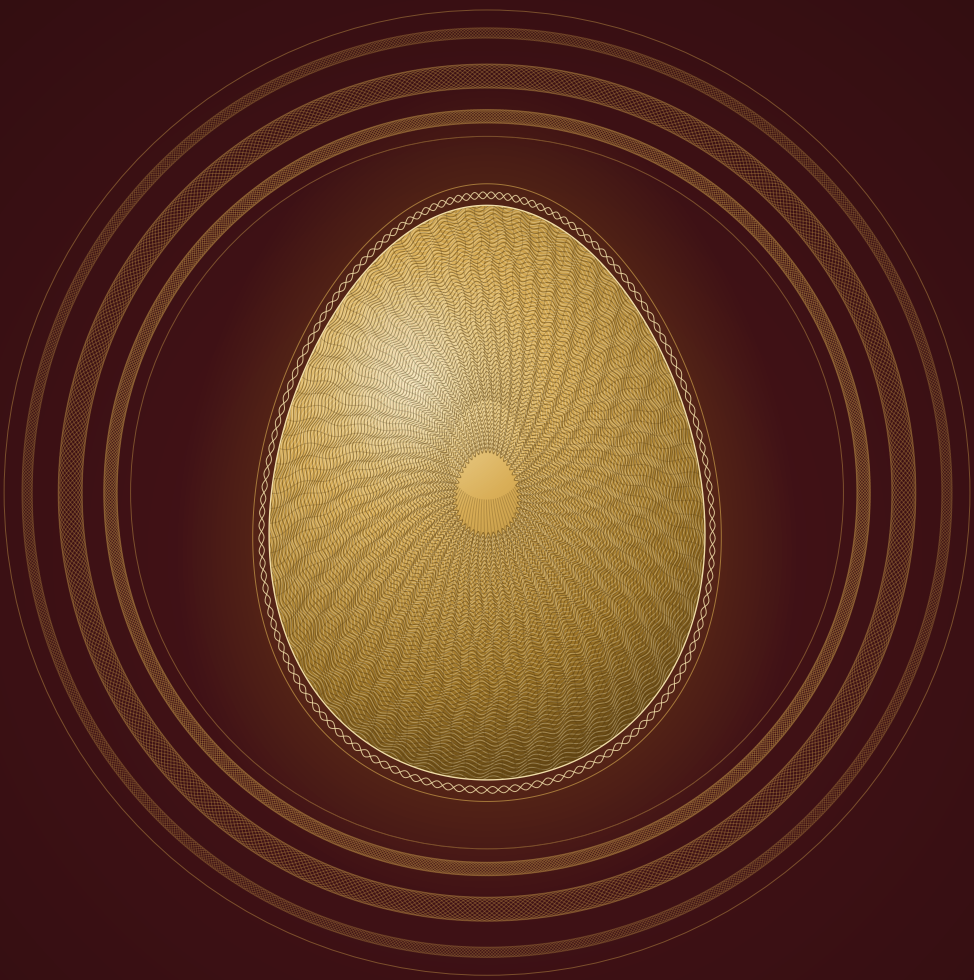
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Golden Eggs and Eyeless Gods

Toward a Xenotocology of the *Alien* Corpus

1979–2025

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that the *Alien* corpus — Ridley Scott's *Alien* (1979), James Cameron's *Aliens* (1986), David Fincher's *Alien*^{3} (1992), Jean-Pierre Jeunet's *Alien Resurrection* (1997), Scott's *Prometheus* (2012) and *Alien: Covenant* (2017), Fede Álvarez's *Alien: Romulus* (2024), and the first season of Noah Hawley's *Alien: Earth* (2025) — constitutes a single polyauteurial myth whose true subject is neither the monster, nor the mother, nor the corporation, but the *host*. Taking its cue from the Greek *tokos*, which names at once a child and the interest on a loan, and from Aristotle's verdict that interest — money bred from money — is the most unnatural mode of acquisition (*Politics* 1258b), it proposes the concept of **xenotokia**, or parasitic generation: a mode of reproduction in which (i) the offspring is categorially foreign to the body that bears it, (ii) gestation is consumption, the host's life becoming the offspring's capital, and (iii) the process is self-valorizing, returning more of itself than it consumed. The xenomorph's life cycle, Weyland-Yutani's accumulation, and the Engineers' sacrificial seeding of life are read as three registers — biological, economic, cosmogonic — of one structure, whose emblem is the egg: Giger's ovomorph, Marx's capital that "lays golden eggs," and the dissolving Engineer as cosmic seed.

Part I reconstructs the corpus's archaeology: its pulp precursors (van Vogt, Bixby, Bava), its pictorial matrix (Giger, Bacon, Böcklin), its maritime and colonial intertexts (Conrad, Coleridge, Poe, Melville, Stoker, Lovecraft), its biological unconscious (Darwin's ichneumon, Medawar's fetal allograft, Haig's maternal–fetal conflict, the retroviral origin of the placenta), and its mythic substrates (Tiamat, Echidna, Polyphemus, Daedalus, the Furies, and Apollo's embryology in the *Eumenides*). Part II offers close exegeses of each installment and traces a dialectical itinerary: xenotokia *disclosed* as industrial horror (1979); *politicized* as a war between two mothers and two Leviathans (1986); *sacralized* as *hostia*, the host who refuses to deliver (1992); *commodified*

as cloned kinship on the "eighth day" (1997); *cosmogonized* as Gnostic demiurgy, in which the made becomes maker (2012, 2017); *historicized* as indenture and franchise self-cannibalization (2024); and finally *inverted* into a fragile, sovereign xenia between dying children and the creature (2025). Part III synthesizes these readings into a general **xenotocology**: the synthetic as Lévi-Straussian mediator — "made, not begotten," the only non-host in a xenotokic cosmos; Ripley and her daughters as bearers of Arendtian natality and elective kinship; the historical archive of *partus sequitur ventrem*, in which the enslaved womb was legally constituted as a site of accumulation; and a Greimasian square — xenia, xenotokia, hostility, fabrication — that maps the corpus's field of possibilities.

The central claim is that the xenomorph is not a monster but a theorem: under the logic of self-valorizing value, every form of generation tends toward xenotokia, and the host — at once hospitable, hostile, and sacrificial (*hospes*, *hostis*, *hostia*) — becomes the decisive figure of modernity. Across nearly half a century the corpus stages the slow, incomplete passage from the horror of *being* a host to the ethics of *hospitality*. Because the franchise is itself an interest-bearing property that gestates each new installment inside the body of its predecessors, the theorem is self-implicating: the corpus is the egg it describes.

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Conventions. Citations follow an author–date system; classical, patristic, and scriptural texts are cited by standard numeration, and translations from Greek are the author's unless noted. Film and television dialogue is paraphrased except where a phrase of a few words is analytically indispensable. "The corpus" designates the eight works named in the Abstract; abandoned scripts, novelizations, comics, games, and crossovers are treated as variants of the myth in Lévi-Strauss's sense, cited where they illuminate the structure.



Prolegomenon

The Problem of the Host

§ 0.1 *The corpus as polyauteurial myth*

No single author owns the *Alien* myth, and that dispersal is the first condition of its seriousness. The 1979 film was assembled from Dan O'Bannon's screenplay and the story he devised with Ronald Shusett; from the Brandywine rewrites of Walter Hill and David Giler, which introduced the android Ash; from H. R. Giger's biomechanical designs, Ron Cobb's industrial interiors, Chris Foss's early hulls, and Jean "Moebius" Giraud's spacesuits; and from Ridley Scott's direction, which welded these incompatible sensibilities into a single atmosphere. Every subsequent installment was authored against its predecessor: Cameron converted a haunted-house film into a war film; Fincher's *Alien*^{3} absorbed, in mutilated form, William Gibson's Cold War script and Vincent Ward's wooden monastery-planet; Joss Whedon regarded his *Resurrection* screenplay as betrayed in its realization; the prequels passed through Jon Spaihts, Damon Lindelof, John Logan, Dante Harper, Jack Paglen, and Michael Green; *Romulus* (Álvarez and Rodo Sayagues) and *Alien: Earth* (Hawley) inherited a mythology already dense with contradiction.

The proper analogy is not the *auteur* but Attic tragedy. Aeschylus, Sophocles, and Euripides reworked the Argive and Theban cycles in deliberate disagreement, and the myth persisted as the structure their disagreements shared. Lévi-Strauss drew the methodological consequence: a myth consists of the totality of its versions, and no version is

the "true" one (Lévi-Strauss 1955). The *Alien* myth therefore includes its abandoned drafts, Alan Dean Foster's novelizations, the Dark Horse comics, and the video game *Alien: Isolation* (2014), whose protagonist, Amanda Ripley, searches for her mother's flight recorder. It includes even the degraded variants *Alien vs. Predator* (2004) and *Requiem* (2007), which domesticate the creature into game for a trophy-hunting culture; they illuminate by negation, showing what the creature becomes once it is merely prey. The question of canon is thus reformulated: not which texts are authorized, but which versions carry the structure.

§0.2 Tokos *and the host: the thesis stated*

The structure is named by an ancient pun. Greek *tokos*, from *tiktein* ("to bear"), signifies offspring, parturition, and the interest on a loan. Aristotle exploits the coincidence to condemn usury: interest is called *tokos* because the offspring resembles the parent, money begotten of money, and "of all modes of getting wealth this is the most unnatural" (*Politics* 1258b, trans. Jowett). Marx inherits the figure. In the general formula of capital, value becomes an *automatisches Subjekt*, a self-moving subject that differentiates itself from itself as surplus, and "brings forth living offspring, or, at the least, lays golden eggs" (Marx 1887 [1867], ch. 4). The usurious contract has a precise anatomy. The lender's principal is the parent; the borrower is the body in which the increment gestates; the interest, when delivered, resembles not the borrower but the lender's money. The borrower is a host.

This dissertation names that anatomy **xenotokia** (*xenos*, stranger, guest, host; *tokos*, birth, offspring, interest) and defines it by five marks:

1. *Alterity of issue.* The offspring is categorially foreign to the body that bears it; it resembles an absent progenitor.
2. *Consumptive gestation.* To bear is to be consumed; the host's life is converted, without remainder, into the offspring's being.
3. *Self-valorization.* The cycle returns more of itself than it consumed: egg, host, drone, queen, eggs; M–C–M′.
4. *Effacement.* The host's face — the organ of address, refusal, and ethical claim — is suspended for the duration of the implantation.
5. *Dissimulation.* Xenotokia presents itself as nurture: a computer called Mother, a Company that calls its crews family, a colony

named Hope, a pharmaceutical gift, a cure for dying children.

The figure in whom these marks converge is the *host*, a word that in English condenses three Latin lineages. *Hospes* yields the host who receives a guest; Benveniste reconstructs it from a compound meaning "master of the guest" (Benveniste 1969, vol. 1). *Hostis* names first the stranger bound by reciprocal obligation and only later the enemy, whence the "host" as army. *Hostia*, the sacrificial victim, yields the eucharistic Host; its derivation is disputed, but its semantic convergence with the other two is ancient. Derrida's neologism "hostipitality" registers the instability: the host who welcomes is always already the master who may expel, and the welcome may become the enemy's entrance (Derrida and Dufourmantelle 1997; Derrida 2000). The xenomorph's host is all three at once. It *receives* the stranger (*hospes*), is converted into the stranger's instrument of war (*hostis*), and is broken open so that another may live (*hostia*).

The thesis follows. The *Alien* corpus is a mythic apparatus for thinking the host under the conditions of self-valorizing value. Its creature is not an allegory of any single referent — rape, AIDS, motherhood, colonialism, or capital — although criticism has proposed each in turn. It is the *theorem* of which these are instances: the formal statement that any generation subsumed under accumulation tends toward xenotokia. Across eight works the corpus unfolds that theorem dialectically, through seven figures (disclosure, politicization, sacralization, commodification, cosmogonization, historicization, inversion), and arrives, haltingly, at the counter-question that xenotokia makes urgent: whether a hospitality toward the radically strange is possible that does not become either parasitism or war.

§0.3 *The state of the field*

Scholarship on the corpus has organized itself around three paradigms, each powerful within its register and each tempted to treat the others as metaphor. The *psychoanalytic-feminist* paradigm, inaugurated by Barbara Creed's account of the archaic mother and the monstrous-feminine (Creed 1986; 1993), extended through Kristevan abjection, and developed by Kavanagh (1980), Newton (1980), Zwinger (1992), Constable (1999), Clover's Final Girl (1992), and Gallardo and Smith (2004),

reads the creature as the return of the maternal body repressed by patriarchal symbolization. The *political-economic* paradigm reads the Company as the unrepresentable totality of late capital (after Jameson 1991), the "used future" as an image of deindustrialization (Luckhurst 2014), and the corporation as an eerie agency without a face (Fisher 2016). The *philosophical* paradigm, most rigorously in Stephen Mulhall's *On Film* (2002; 3rd ed. 2016), reads the films as thinking in their own medium about embodiment, finitude, and the self's relation to its own flesh, while Noël Carroll's theory of the categorically interstitial monster (Carroll 1990) supplies the corpus with a formal ontology. Studies of Reagan-era bodies (Jeffords 1994; Tasker 1993) and of the franchise's production history (Thomson 1998) complete the field.

Three lacunae follow. First, no paradigm unifies reproduction, accumulation, and theology under a single concept; each sees one register and allegorizes the others. Second, the prequels' theological and cosmogonic turn has been treated chiefly as a failure of coherence rather than as a structural intensification. Third, the post-2020 installments, *Romulus* and *Alien: Earth*, which return the myth to labor and childhood respectively, have scarcely entered the scholarly record. The concept of the host is proposed here as the term in which the three paradigms become commensurable: the mother, the worker, and the sacrificial victim are, in the corpus's logic, three names for the body in which a stranger's increment gestates.

§0.4 *Method and architecture*

The method is deliberately plural but not eclectic, because each instrument answers to one register of the theorem. Structural anthropology (Lévi-Strauss 1955) and Greimasian semiotics, read through Jameson's political unconscious (Jameson 1981), supply the logic of mediation and contradiction. Psychoanalysis (Freud, Klein, Lacan, Kristeva) supplies the economy of the drive and the maternal body. Political economy (Aristotle, Marx, Weber, Mbembe) supplies the economy of accumulation. Political theology and philosophy (the Gnostic sources as read by Jonas 1958, patristic Christology, Arendt, Levinas, Derrida) supply the economy of sacrifice, creation, and hospitality. A fifth instrument is less conventional: a *biological unconscious*, in which the life sciences are read as the repressed literal of the myth — the place where what the

films fantasize is already, prosaically, true.

Part I (Chapters 1–3) excavates the corpus's literary, pictorial, biological, and mythic strata. Part II (Chapters 4–10) reads each installment closely, in order, as a moment of the dialectic. Part III (Chapters 11–13) constructs the general theory: the synthetic as mediator, the Ripleyan lineage as counter-principle, and the theorem of the host with its historical archive and its semiotic square.



Archaeologies

Of all modes of getting wealth this is the most unnatural.

Aristotle, *Politics* 1258b, trans. Jowett



1

The Pulp, the Pictorial, and the Maritime

Sources of the Xenomorph

The xenomorph was assembled rather than invented: its plot descends from American pulp, its body from Swiss and British painting, its ships from Conrad, and its dread from a lineage of maritime horror running from Coleridge to Lovecraft. Reconstructing that lineage is not source-hunting for its own sake. Each stratum deposits one register of xenotokia, and the corpus is the place where they first fuse.

§1.1 *Pulp genealogy and the plagiarism of necessity*

The narrative skeleton — a crew, a sealed vessel, a predator that reproduces through their bodies — is older than the film by four decades. A. E. van Vogt's "Black Destroyer" (*Astounding*, July 1939) and "Discord in Scarlet" (*Astounding*, December 1939), later fused into *The Voyage of the Space Beagle* (1950), feature a creature, the Ixtl, that deposits its eggs inside the living bodies of the crew; van Vogt's suit against Twentieth Century-Fox was settled out of court. Jerome Bixby's screenplay for *It! The Terror from Beyond Space* (Edward L. Cahn, 1958) supplies the stowaway, the ventilation ducts, the crew picked off one by one, and the airlock as last resort. Mario Bava's *Planet of the Vampires* (1965) supplies

a derelict alien vessel housing the remains of giants, the direct ancestor of the Space Jockey. O'Bannon's own *Dark Star* (with John Carpenter, 1974) contains the farcical prototype: a beach-ball alien pursuing a crewman through an elevator shaft, a sequence O'Bannon resolved to remake as terror.

Two further facts of origin are structurally decisive. The first is that the creature's design team was assembled from the wreckage of another body. Alejandro Jodorowsky's abandoned *Dune* (1974–76) brought O'Bannon together with Giger, Foss, and Moebius; when it collapsed, its personnel migrated into *Alien*. The franchise was born, in a precise sense, from the corpse of a host. The second is somatic. O'Bannon suffered from Crohn's disease, and the visceral pain of an inflamed gut is widely cited as one source of the chestburster; he also stated, in interviews, that he set out to assault the male spectator with images of oral violation and male pregnancy. His screenplay specified a unisex crew whose roles could be played by men or women interchangeably — the formal precondition of Ripley, and the first sign that the corpus would treat gender as a position within a reproductive economy rather than an essence.

Even the title encodes the structure. O'Bannon noticed that "alien" functions as both noun and adjective. Its Latin root, *alienus*, means "belonging to another," and its legal derivative, *alienation*, names the transfer of title in property. Hegel and Marx made *Entfremdung* and *Entäußerung* the names for the worker's estrangement from a product that confronts him as an alien power. The title already names a thing whose being consists in belonging to another — the precise condition of the host.

§1.2 *Giger: biomechanics and the birth machine*

H. R. Giger's *Necronomicon* (1977) — its title borrowed from Lovecraft's invented grimoire, the book whose reading destroys — provided the matrix of the adult creature in the painting *Necronom IV* (1976). Giger's idiom, which he called biomechanics, refuses the distinction between flesh and machine on which industrial modernity depends: vertebrae become pistons, phalluses become conduits, wombs become ducts. His lineage runs through the Vienna School of Fantastic Realism (Ernst Fuchs), Alfred Kubin's nocturnes, Bosch's hybrid infernos, and Arnold

Böcklin, to whom he paid explicit tribute in *Hommage à Böcklin* (1977). Carlo Rambaldi engineered the head's mechanics and its extensible inner jaw; he would later build the creature for Andrzej Żuławski's *Possession* (1981), whose heroine miscarries a monster in a subway underpass. Giger, Rambaldi, Brian Johnson, Nick Allder, and Denys Ayling shared the Academy Award for Visual Effects.

One early work deserves elevation to the status of emblem. Giger's *Birth Machine* (*Geburtsmaschine*, 1967) depicts a pistol whose cartridges are goggled infants. Generation is figured as ballistics; birth is fired. The image condenses, a decade before the film, the conjunction this dissertation calls the hive deixis (Chapter 13): xenotokia fused with hostility, the reproductive body as a weapon system.

§1.3 *Bacon's Furies*

Francis Bacon's *Three Studies for Figures at the Base of a Crucifixion* (1944) is frequently adduced as a source for the chestburster's eyeless, toothed lunge on an elongated neck. Bacon associated the figures with the Eumenides of Aeschylus's *Oresteia* and conceived them as studies for a larger crucifixion. The triptych is thus proleptic of the whole corpus. Its Furies return as the planet Fiorina "Fury" 161, and its crucifixion returns as Ripley's cruciform descent into molten lead (Chapter 6). The chain Aeschylus → Bacon → Giger and Scott → Fincher is one of the corpus's deepest arteries: the chthonic, female, avenging powers of archaic justice, set beneath the instrument of the god's sacrifice.

§1.4 *Conrad's ships*

The corpus's nautical nomenclature is a reading list in the literature of extraction. The *Nostromo* is named for Conrad's 1904 novel of the San Tomé silver mine, in which "material interests" corrupt every allegiance and the incorruptible man is undone by the treasure entrusted to him; Scott's ship hauls twenty million tons of mineral ore. Cameron's warship *Sulaco* is named for that novel's port, from which the silver of the Occidental Province is shipped. The shuttle *Narcissus* recalls Conrad's 1897 novel of that ship (published in America as *The Children of the Sea*), in which a dying sailor, James Wait, becomes the political center of the crew, binding and demoralizing them through the spectacle of his failing body. Kane is the *Nostromo*'s Wait: a sick body around which the

ship's polity reorganizes, and inside which its doom gestates.

Heart of Darkness (1899) supplies the deeper template: an unnamed Company, a voyage into extraction, a sepulchral metropolis, and a report on civilizing the natives whose scrawled postscript reads "Exterminate all the brutes!" Special Order 937, which instructs the ship's computer to return the organism at any cost and declares the crew expendable, is Kurtz's postscript rewritten in the prose of corporate administration. "The Secret Sharer" (1910), in which a captain conceals his fugitive double in his own cabin, anticipates the final sequence aboard the *Narcissus*, where Ripley and the creature share a single cramped chamber as secret sharers.

§1.5 *Maritime horror: Coleridge, Stoker, Poe, Melville*

The sea-horror tradition supplies the corpus's narrative grammar. Coleridge's "Rime of the Ancient Mariner" (1798) gives the death-ship, the curse that falls on a crew for an offense against a creature, and the sole survivor condemned to narrate; Ripley's closing log, in which she names herself the last survivor of the *Nostromo*, belongs to the Mariner's genre and, behind it, to the messengers of Job, each of whom alone escaped to tell. Chapter 7 of Stoker's *Dracula* (1897) — the log of the *Demeter*, whose crew vanish one by one until the captain is found lashed to the wheel — is the proximate template of the film's plot: an unseen predator in the hold of a commercial vessel, recorded in the captain's own hand. Stephen Arata's reading of *Dracula* as a fantasy of "reverse colonization" (Arata 1990) applies with equal force to a creature that colonizes the colonizers' bodies.

Poe's *Narrative of Arthur Gordon Pym* (1838) ends with a shrouded human figure, far larger than any man, whose skin has "the perfect whiteness of the snow." Melville's chapter on "The Whiteness of the Whale" (1851) theorizes that pallor as "a dumb blankness, full of meaning." Lovecraft wrote *At the Mountains of Madness* (1936) as Pym's sequel: the Elder Things seed terrestrial life, breed the shoggoths as servants, and are overthrown by them. Here, almost entire, is the cosmogony of *Prometheus* and *Covenant* — pale giant progenitors, life seeded by design, a servant-creation that revolts — and Guillermo del Toro publicly shelved his adaptation in 2012 because Scott's film covered the same ground. The Engineers' marble whiteness thus descends from Poe

through Melville and Lovecraft, and behind them from Winckelmann's white antiquity (1764), whose racialized afterlife the prequels inherit without examining (Chapter 8).

Lovecraft bequeaths two further things. One is a principle: that the oldest and strongest fear is fear of the unknown (Lovecraft 1927), and that cosmic indifference, not malice, is the ground of horror. The other is a phobia: the horror of mixed descent that drives "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1936). The corpus inherits both, and will spend its later installments inverting the second, until the hybrid becomes kin (Chapters 7 and 10). John W. Campbell's "Who Goes There?" (1938), filmed by Carpenter as *The Thing* (1982), marks the decisive contrast. The Thing *imitates*; its horror is epistemological, a paranoia about who is still human. The xenomorph *incorporates*; its horror is ontological and economic, a certainty about what a body is being used for.



2

The Biological Unconscious

Parasitoids, Allografts, and the Viral Placenta

Everything the xenomorph does, terrestrial life already does; the franchise's horror is the return of biological knowledge that the modern sentiment of generation has repressed. Freud's formula for the uncanny — the familiar that ought to have remained hidden and has come to light — applies here with unusual literalness. What the films stage as alien is, at the level of the life sciences, the prosaic truth about how mammals, cells, and genomes come to be.

§2.1 *Darwin's ichneumon and the zero degree of theodicy*

The xenomorph's life cycle is modeled on the parasitoid wasp, whose larvae develop inside a living host and emerge by consuming it. The biological literature distinguishes *idiobionts*, which paralyze their host at oviposition, from *koinobionts*, which allow the host to resume normal life while the larva grows. Kane's apparent recovery and hearty appetite before the chestburst is textbook koinobiosis. Some braconid wasps go further: in *Glyptapanteles*, the surviving caterpillar stands guard over the wasp pupae that have just erupted from it, a "bodyguard" manipulation that *Alien*[3] will invert when the creature guards the woman who carries its queen.

For Darwin, the parasitoid was the decisive objection to benevolent design. To Asa Gray he wrote, on 22 May 1860: "I cannot persuade my-

self that a beneficent & omnipotent God would have designedly created the Ichneumonidae with the express intention of their feeding within the living bodies of caterpillars." Stephen Jay Gould later made the letter the occasion for an essay on "nonmoral nature," arguing that the ichneumon is neither cruel nor kind, simply outside the jurisdiction of ethics (Gould 1982). Annie Dillard's chapter "Fecundity" (1974) records the same vertigo from the side of the creature: nature's prodigality of birth, waste, and parasitism, which makes generation itself appear monstrous. The corpus's theological question — who made this, and why — is Darwin's question. *Prometheus* and *Covenant* will answer it in the most disturbing way available: there *is* a designer, and he admires the ichneumon (Chapter 8).

§2.2 *Medawar's paradox: the fetus as stranger*

In 1953 Peter Medawar formulated what immunology still calls the paradox of the fetus. Because the fetus expresses paternal antigens, it is, immunologically, a semi-allograft — tissue that a mother's immune system ought to reject as foreign (Medawar 1953). Pregnancy is therefore not the plenitude of the same but a regulated hospitality toward a partly foreign body, sustained by local suppression of the defenses that would expel it. The relation does not end at birth. Fetal cells persist in maternal tissues for decades after delivery (Bianchi et al. 1996), so that every mother remains, in a cellular sense, permanently inhabited by her children. The maternal body is the first host, and the condition the corpus names "alien" is a hypertrophy of the ordinary.

§2.3 *Haig's conflict: the father's genes as extractors*

David Haig's theory of genomic conflict in pregnancy sharpens Medawar's paradox into economics. Because a mother's future offspring may have different fathers, natural selection favors paternally expressed genes that extract more maternal resources for the present fetus than is optimal for the mother, and maternally expressed genes that restrain them (Haig 1993). The placenta becomes a contested frontier where fetal signals raise maternal blood glucose and blood pressure, and certain pathologies of pregnancy appear as symptoms of the conflict. Genomic imprinting — the silencing of a gene according to its parent of origin — is the molecular ledger of this negotiation.

In Haig's model, the father's genome is literally a creditor drawing interest on the mother's body. Aeschylus's Apollo, who declares the mother merely the nurse of a seed sown by another (Chapter 3), has acquired a molecular biology.

§2.4 *The viral placenta and the colonial cell*

The organ of mammalian hospitality is itself of alien origin. Syncytin-1, the protein that fuses placental cells into the syncytiotrophoblast at the maternal–fetal boundary, derives from the envelope gene of an endogenous retrovirus captured by the primate genome millions of years ago (Mi et al. 2000). Roughly eight percent of the human genome consists of such retroviral remnants (International Human Genome Sequencing Consortium 2001). The capacity to carry a child depends on a domesticated infection. One level further down, Lynn Margulis's theory of endosymbiosis established that mitochondria, the energy organelles of every eukaryotic cell, descend from free-living bacteria once engulfed and retained (Sagan 1967; Margulis 1998). The human body is a xenotokic palimpsest: a colony of former strangers whose incorporation is the condition of its life.

§2.5 *The extended phenotype and the commandeered host*

Richard Dawkins recast organisms as "survival machines" built by replicators for their own propagation (Dawkins 1976) and extended the gene's reach into the bodies of others: a parasite's genes may express themselves in its host's behavior (Dawkins 1982). The examples read like a bestiary for the later corpus. The lancet liver fluke drives infected ants to clamp themselves to grass tips where grazing sheep will eat them. *Toxoplasma gondii* dampens rodents' aversion to the smell of cats. The fungus *Ophiocordyceps* steers ants to a lethal perch before fruiting from their heads. Most uncannily, the trematode *Leucochloridium paradoxum* invades the eyestalks of snails, which swell and pulsate so that birds mistake them for caterpillars. An ocular parasite that commandeers its host's visible body is not an invention of *Alien: Earth*; it is a fact of the snail.

§2.6 *Directed panspermia and the superorganism*

The prequels' cosmogony also has a scientific pedigree. In 1973 Francis Crick, co-discoverer of the double helix, and Leslie Orgel proposed "directed panspermia": the hypothesis that terrestrial life was deliberately seeded by an extraterrestrial civilization (Crick and Orgel 1973). The prologue of *Prometheus* is that hypothesis, filmed. Cameron's hive, finally, draws on the entomology of eusociality — the colony as a single organism whose reproductive function is concentrated in one queen (Wilson 1975; Hölldobler and Wilson 2009) — and behind it on Maurice Maeterlinck's *Life of the Bee* (1901), with its invisible sovereign, the "spirit of the hive."

§2.7 *The return of the biological repressed*

The consequence for interpretation is decisive. The fetus is a partial stranger; the placenta is a tamed virus; the father's genome is extractive; the cell is a colony; parasites write their will into the bodies of hosts; life may have been seeded by design. The ideology of maternal plenitude, which presents generation as the reproduction of the same in a medium of pure gift, must repress all of this. The corpus is where it returns. Its monster is not unnatural; it is nature with the sentiment removed — generation as it appears once the host is no longer permitted to mistake itself for the parent.



3

Mythic Matrices

Tiamat, the Cyclops, Daedalus, and the Law of the Stranger

The corpus reactivates the oldest stratum of Near Eastern and Mediterranean myth, in which generation, monstrosity, labor, and the law of the stranger are not yet separated. Read against that stratum, the franchise's apparent novelties — acid blood, an egg-laying sovereign, gods who regret their creatures, a mother who is only a nurse — appear as the return of mythemes that antiquity had already formulated with precision.

§3.1 *Tiamat's brood and the labor of the made*

In the Babylonian *Enuma Elish*, the primordial mother Tiamat spawns eleven monsters to war against the younger gods, and of them the text says: "With poison, instead of blood, she filled their bodies" (Tablet I, trans. King 1902). The xenomorph's acid blood — blood that is itself a weapon, that eats through decks and defeats dissection — is Tiamat's signature. Marduk slays her, splits her body in two to make heaven and earth, and then, at Ea's direction, fashions humankind from the blood of her slain general Kingu so that humans may bear the toil from which the gods would rest (Tablet VI). The cosmogony thus ends in a political economy: the cosmos is a mother's corpse, and humanity is manufactured labor. When Ripley confronts the Queen in *Aliens*, the scene restages the matricidal combat that founds the Babylonian cosmos, with

the decisive difference that the Marduk-position is occupied by another mother (Chapter 5).

The Old Babylonian *Atrahasis* makes the economy explicit. Its incipit, *inūma ilū awīlum*, "when the gods were man," names a time when the gods themselves did the labor. The junior gods, the Igigi, burn their tools and besiege Enlil's house — the first labor strike in literature — and the dispute is resolved by creating humans from clay mixed with the flesh and blood of a slain god, to take over the work. When human noise multiplies, the gods regret their creation and send plague, drought, and flood; the Hebrew flood narrative preserves the motif in the verse that "it repented the LORD that he had made man on the earth" (Genesis 6:6, KJV). Here, nearly four millennia early, is the plot of the prequels: a race made from a slain god's substance, made *for* work, and a maker who decides to unmake it. The *Epic of Gilgamesh* supplies the complement in its hero's journey to Utnapishtim, the flood's survivor, to demand immortality — the journey Peter Weyland repeats in *Prometheus*, with the same result. Zecharia Sitchin's pseudo-scholarship, which reads the Anunnaki as extraterrestrials who engineered humans to mine gold (Sitchin 1976), is worthless as history and revealing as symptom: modern fantasy cannot imagine the gods except as a mining company.

§ 3.2 *Mothers of monsters: Echidna and Lilith*

Hesiod's Echidna is half a nymph with glancing eyes and half a vast, raw-eating serpent, dwelling in a hollow cave beneath the earth and bearing the monsters that heroes must later kill (*Theogony* 295–332). The Queen of *Aliens*, enthroned in the hive beneath the atmosphere processor, her human-like crest above an insectoid abdomen, is an Echidna whose brood is serial rather than heroic. Jewish folklore supplies the infanticidal variant. In the medieval *Alphabet of Ben Sira*, Lilith, Adam's first wife, refuses to lie beneath him, departs, and becomes a demoness who threatens newborns unless amulets bearing three angelic names protect them. Octavia Butler will name the mother of her hybrid species Lilith (Chapter 12); *Alien Resurrection* will make Ripley a Lilith who bears, by proxy, a hybrid child and then destroys it (Chapter 7).

§3.3 *Medusa and the face*

Freud read Medusa's severed head as the sight of castration, its serpent-hair multiplying the absent phallus, its petrifying gaze both terror and consolation, and its display on Athena's aegis as an apotropaic weapon (Freud 1940 [1922]). The facehugger inverts the Gorgon. Medusa is a face that annihilates whoever looks at it; the facehugger is a hand-shaped, finger-legged, genital body that annihilates the face it grips — covering the eyes, occupying the mouth, coiling its tail around the throat. Where the Gorgon kills by being seen, the facehugger kills sight itself. Chapter 4 will develop the consequence through Levinas: the creature's first act is to abolish the organ of ethical address.

§3.4 *Polyphemus, or the anti-host*

The oldest version of the *Alien* plot in Western literature is the ninth book of the *Odyssey*. A crew enters a giant's cave, is sealed in by a boulder, and is devoured two at a time. Polyphemus's crime is a violation of *xenia*, the sacred law of guest-friendship under the protection of Zeus Xenios: he answers the strangers' claim to hospitality by eating them, and he mocks the institution itself by promising Odysseus, as a guest-gift (*xeinion*), that "Nobody" will be eaten last (9.369–70). The Cyclops is the anti-host: the host who consumes his guests. The crew escape by clinging beneath the giant's sheep; *Alien: Earth*, by convergence or design, places its one-eyed parasite inside a sheep (Chapter 10). The *Odyssey*'s climax is the inverse transgression. The suitors are bad guests who consume the absent master's substance; the master returns and slaughters them (Book 22). *Prometheus* restages that scene when the sleeping Engineer wakes among intruders who have been opening his vessels and kills them (Chapter 8).

§3.5 *Daedalus, the first Engineer*

If the prequels' "Engineers" have a mythic archetype, it is Daedalus, the Athenian craftsman whose name means "cunningly wrought." For Queen Pasiphaë he built a wooden cow so that she could couple with Poseidon's bull; the offspring was the Minotaur, and Daedalus then built the Labyrinth to contain it (Apollodorus, *Bibliotheca* 3.1.4; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 8.152–68). The sequence — artifice enables a monstrous hybrid birth, and the artificer then engineers its containment — is the his-

tory of the xenomorph in the prequels. Daedalus was also the maker of moving statues. Plato compares true opinions to them, because they run away unless tethered (*Meno* 97d–e); Aristotle imagines them, with Hephaestus's self-moving tripods, as the condition under which masters would no longer need slaves (*Politics* 1253b; Chapter 11). Daedalus thus unites the three figures of the corpus's technics: the maker of hybrids, the builder of mazes, and the father of automata who will not stay put. In the *Alien*[3] Assembly Cut, where the creature gestates in an ox and is hunted through the prison's ducts into a mold, the Minotaur and its labyrinth return almost to the letter (Chapter 6).

§3.6 *Apollo's embryology: the mother as stranger*

The single most important ancient text for the corpus is a speech in Aeschylus's *Eumenides* (458 BCE). Defending Orestes for killing his mother, Apollo argues: "She who is called the mother is not the child's begetter (*tokeus*) but the nurse of the newly sown embryo. The one who mounts begets; she, a stranger for a stranger (*xenōi xenē*), keeps the shoot safe, if no god harms it" (657–61). As proof, he points to Athena, born from Zeus without a mother. The passage is saturated with the vocabulary this dissertation employs. The mother is denied the status of *tokeus*; she is a *xenē*, a stranger-host, preserving the seed of a *xenos*. Apollo's embryology is xenotokia formulated as law: generation is something that happens *in* a woman on behalf of a stranger, and the woman is a vessel whose blood relation to the issue can be denied in court. The xenomorph literalizes Apollo's theory and extends it without regard to sex. Kane, Brett, the colonists of Hadley's Hope, and the prisoners of Fury 161 all become Apollo's nurse.

Athena's deciding vote acquits Orestes, and the Furies, the chthonic avengers of kin-blood, are persuaded to become the Eumenides and dwell beneath Athens. Luce Irigaray reads this as Western culture's founding matricide: the murdered mother is not avenged, and her avengers are buried under the city as honored guests (Irigaray 1993 [1981]). The corpus will return to that settlement on a planet named Fury (Chapter 6).

Lévi-Strauss's analysis of the Oedipus cycle provides the formal key. He found beneath the Theban myths a question about origin: is the human born from one, the earth, or from two, man and woman? (Lévi-

Strauss 1955). The *Alien* corpus multiplies the answers beyond any ancient precedent: born from a stranger through a host (the xenomorph); from one (the clone Ripley 8); from a dissolving god (the Engineer's seed); from a machine (the synthetics); from a dead woman and a machine (David's creature); from a child's mind poured into a made body (the hybrids). The myth's work is to stage, and fail to resolve, the contradiction between generation as reproduction of the same and generation as production of the other.

§3.7 *Theoxeny and the stranger-god*

Greek and Roman myth tests every polity by its reception of strangers who may be gods in disguise. Philemon and Baucis, alone among a thousand households, receive the disguised Jupiter and Mercury, share their meager meal, and are spared when their inhospitable neighbors are drowned (*Metamorphoses* 8.618–724). Lycaon, tested by the same disguised god, slits the throat of a hostage sent by the Molossians and serves his flesh at table; he is turned into a wolf (*Metamorphoses* 1.209–43). The pairing is exact: the hospitable host versus the cannibal host whose dish is a hostage. Euripides' *Bacchae* (405 BCE) makes the stranger a god. Dionysus enters Thebes as a Lydian *xenos*; Pentheus imprisons him; the women, possessed, tear the king apart, and his mother Agave carries his head home believing it a lion's. Refusing hospitality to the divine stranger ends in a mother's sparagmos of her son. These are the myths the corpus will invert when its own stranger arrives: here it is the guest who devours, and the host who must decide whether to open the door.

§3.8 *Prometheus, Pandora, and the dismembered god*

The prequels' titular myth is the theft of fire, but its fuller Hesiodic form matters more. Prometheus's gift is answered by Pandora, whose jar releases every evil into the world while Hope (*elpis*) remains inside beneath its lip (*Works and Days* 90–105). In a later tradition, Prometheus molds human beings from earth and water in the image of the gods (*Metamorphoses* 1.82–83). His punishment is an eagle that devours his liver each day while the liver regrows each night — a regenerating body perpetually consumed, the host as inexhaustible stock. It is the purest image of the extraction the Company desires.

The prologue of *Prometheus* adds a different mythologem: the god who dissolves his own body to seed a world. The Orphic Zagreus, torn apart by the Titans, gives rise to humankind from the soot of his destroyers (Olympiodorus, *In Phaedonem* 1.3). The Vedic Puruṣa is sacrificed by the gods, and from his limbs come the cosmos and the four social orders (*Ṛgveda* 10.90). The Norse Ymir is dismembered to make the world, and in Snorri's account the dwarves, the smiths and makers, first quicken as maggots in his flesh (*Gylfaginning* 14). In these cosmogonies, sacrifice is generative and creation is a parasitism upon a divine corpse. The corpus's cosmogony will be the same, with one modern addition: the corpse is engineered, and the makers who seed it can still decide to end it.

TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA



II

Exegeses

ἡ δ᾽ ἄπερ ξένῳ ξένη ἔσωσεν ἔρνος

She, a stranger for a stranger, keeps the shoot safe.

Aeschylus, *Eumenides* 660 – 61

TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA



4

Alien (1979)

The Haunted Factory and the Hommelette

Scott's film discloses xenotokia as the occluded truth of a commercial vessel: the crew are hosts long before the creature arrives, and the creature merely makes visible the use to which their bodies had already been assigned. Its horror is not that something alien enters the system. It is that the system was already organized for the alien's reception.

§4.1 *The haunted factory*

The opening title is an inventory, not an invocation: a commercial towing vehicle, a crew of seven, a refinery processing twenty million tons of mineral ore, a course for Earth. The *Nostromo* is a moving factory, and its crew are among its working parts. Ron Cobb's interiors — scuffed consoles, coffee cups, girlie pin-ups, condensation — created the "used future" that Roger Luckhurst identifies as the film's quiet revolution in science-fiction design (Luckhurst 2014). This is space as a workplace, not a frontier. The class topology is explicit. Dallas, Kane, and Ripley command from the bridge; Parker and Brett labor in engineering, complain about their bonus shares, and are excluded from information. The first argument aboard the ship concerns the division of surplus. Brett dies in the ship's viscera, among dripping chains, while searching for the cat — a worker consumed in the bowels of the machine he main-

tains.

The crew are not woken by their destination but by the Company's interest. They are, in Heidegger's sense, *thrown*: delivered into a situation whose terms were set before they became aware of it (Heidegger 1927). The narrative of the film is the slow discovery of those terms.

§ 4.2 *Mother*

The film's first birth is mechanical. In a white nursery of hypersleep pods, lids lift like petals and the crew emerge in white, blinking, as if newborn; the ship's computer, MU-TH-UR 6000, has woken its children. Its interface chamber is a padded white room studded with lights, a womb fitted with a keyboard. Barbara Creed reads the film as an encounter with the archaic mother, the generative and devouring figure that precedes paternal law (Creed 1993). The point can be sharpened through Melanie Klein. The infant splits its first object into a good breast that nourishes and a bad breast that persecutes (Klein 1946). Mother is both. She wakes, feeds, and guides; and she conceals Special Order 937, which instructs her to ensure the organism's return, subordinates every other consideration, and concludes: "Crew expendable."

Those two words are the axiom of xenotokia in its economic form. They declare that the crew's lives are the medium in which another value is to be carried home. Ripley's rage at the computer when the self-destruct cannot be aborted is the infant's fury at the bad breast — and, simultaneously, the worker's discovery that the maternal interface of her employer was always the face of capital. Here the fifth mark of xenotokia, dissimulation, is first established: extraction wears the mask of nurture.

§ 4.3 *The inverted call*

Mother wakes the crew because she has intercepted a transmission from LV-426. It is treated as a distress call; Ripley's partial decoding suggests that it is a warning. Hans Jonas reconstructs, across the Gnostic and Mandaean literatures, a myth of the *call*: the soul lies asleep in an alien world, intoxicated and forgetful, until a call from the transcendent "alien Life" awakens it to knowledge of its origin (Jonas 1958). Its most beautiful expression is the Syriac "Hymn of the Pearl" (*Acts of Thomas* 108–13). A prince is sent into Egypt to fetch a pearl guarded by a serpent; he falls

asleep in forgetfulness; a letter from his parents wakes him; he charms the serpent, takes the pearl, and returns home.

Alien is the Hymn inverted. The crew sleep in the ship; a signal awakens them; they are sent, unknowingly, to fetch the thing the Company covets; and the pearl turns out to be the serpent. Gnosis is catastrophe. The call came not from Life beyond the cosmos but from a necropolis, and the knowledge it confers is knowledge of what bodies are for.

§4.4 *The derelict and the fossilized pilot*

Giger's derelict is architecture as anatomy: ribbed corridors, osseous vaults, entrances shaped like labia. It literalizes Freud's observation that the uncanny place par excellence is the female genital, the entrance to the former home of every human being (Freud 1919). Inside sits the film's most consequential image: a giant pilot fossilized in his chair, his chest burst open from within. The gods were hosts. Xenotokia is not punishment for human hubris but a cosmic condition that preceded humanity and consumed beings far greater than it. Kane's descent to the egg chamber, beneath a luminous blue membrane, is a *katabasis* in the epic sense: a journey to the underworld, where the dead are stored as eggs.

§4.5 *The hommelette*

In the 1964 seminar on the four fundamental concepts, Lacan offered a myth to rival Aristophanes' in the *Symposium*. Libido, he proposed, should be pictured as an organ — a thin, amoeba-like lamella of pure, immortal, irrepressible life, the life that the living being loses by being subject to sexed reproduction and death. It flies off when the membranes of the egg are broken; Lacan called it the *hommelette*, the man-omelette, and imagined it gliding over the face of a sleeper (Lacan 1977 [1964], ch. 15). Fifteen years later the facehugger leaps from a broken egg onto Kane's face. Slavoj Žižek has repeatedly glossed Scott's creature through the lamella, and the match is closer than analogy: the facehugger is undead life itself, the drive without a subject, crossing from the egg to the face.

Its target is not incidental. For Levinas, the face is the epiphany of the other person, and its first expression is the command not to kill (Levinas 1969 [1961]). The facehugger effaces the face. It covers the eyes,

occupies the mouth, and coils its tail around the throat; it suspends the organ through which another could refuse, plead, or command. This is the fourth mark of xenotokia. It is also a parody of care, because the facehugger keeps its host breathing and alive. And it cannot be removed without killing the host, since its blood is acid: the host is also a hostage.

The sequence contains the corpus's first ethical decision, and it is a refusal of hospitality. When the landing party returns with Kane, Ripley, in command, invokes quarantine and will not open the hatch. Ash opens it. The film thus begins with Derrida's aporia in its starkest form: absolute hospitality admits the parasite, and the agent of unconditional welcome is the agent of the Company (Derrida and Dufourmantelle 1997).

§4.6 *The last supper*

Kane revives, hungry, and the crew share a meal before returning to sleep. Mid-meal, his chest erupts and a phallic infant tears through his sternum onto the table, surveys the assembled family, and flees. The scene was staged so that several actors were not fully prepared for its violence, and their shock is part of the record. Its structure is liturgical. At the Last Supper the host breaks bread and says, "this is my body, which is broken for you" (1 Corinthians 11:24, KJV); at the *Nostromo*'s table a body is broken so that a stranger may live. Kane is *hostia*, the sacrificial host; the table is the altar of an inverted mass; communion becomes contamination.

The birth through the breastbone — the site of nursing — is O'Bannon's revenge on the male spectator: a man made pregnant by oral violation, delivering through his own chest. In Kristeva's terms it is abjection at its limit, a rupture of the boundary between inside and outside that confronts the subject with the corpse it will become (Kristeva 1982 [1980]). In Aeschylus's terms, it is Apollo's embryology executed on a man: Kane has been the *xenē* who kept a stranger's shoot.

§4.7 *Ash, or the milk of the machine*

When Parker strikes Ash's head off, the science officer leaks a milky white fluid. The android bleeds the substance of nursing; he is Mother's son and the Company's agent. His attempt to kill Ripley by forcing a rolled pornographic magazine down her throat, in a room decorated

with pin-ups, is the facehugger's act performed by mimicry. The machine can violate only through a simulacrum, a phallus made of images. Klein's bad breast has been built: an artificial body that leaks milk and suffocates.

Reactivated, the severed head delivers the film's only theory of its monster. Ash calls it a perfect organism whose structural perfection is matched only by its "hostility," and confesses that he admires its purity: a survivor, unclouded by conscience, remorse, or delusions of morality. The language is Nietzschean. It describes a being beyond good and evil (Nietzsche 1886), a beast of prey innocent of *ressentiment* (Nietzsche 1887, I.11). And it names the creature, precisely, by *hostis*.

The encomium refutes itself. The "purest" organism in the corpus is the most dependent being imaginable, since it cannot survive a single generation without hosts. Ash praises as autonomy what is absolute parasitism. Hegel had shown that the master who wins recognition becomes dependent on the servant's labor (Hegel 1977 [1807]); Marx described capital as "dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour" (Marx 1887 [1867], ch. 10). Ash's admiration is capital recognizing itself in an organism that, like capital, mistakes total dependence for sovereignty.

§ 4.8 *The* Narcissus

Ripley escapes in a shuttle named for the youth who mistook his reflection for another, and the final sequence turns on misrecognition. As she undresses, the camera concedes to the regime of "to-be-looked-at-ness" that Laura Mulvey identified with classical cinema (Mulvey 1975), a concession feminist critics have rightly noted. The creature is hidden in the shuttle's machinery, indistinguishable from its pipes: Giger's biomechanics becomes camouflage, and the monster is literally at home in the apparatus. Ripley sings "You Are My Lucky Star" as she suits up, a lullaby addressed to herself and obliquely to the thing she is about to expel. She opens the airlock; the creature clings to the frame and is burned by the engines. The shuttle's evacuation is a birth through a mechanical canal, or an abortion. Then Ripley records her log as the sole survivor and returns to hypersleep with the cat. Freud called the drive to return to an earlier, inorganic state the death drive (Freud 1920); the pod is womb and tomb at once.

The disclosure is complete. Mother, the Company, and the creature are three faces of one process, in which a body's life is the medium for another's increment. Ripley survives by two refusals: she will not open the door, and she will not be a host.



5

Aliens (1986)

Two Mothers and the Military-Industrial Hive

Cameron converts xenotokia from a secret into a war, and from a single organism into a sovereign hive confronted by a second, adoptive mother. Where Scott disclosed the structure, Cameron politicizes it: the host becomes an army (*hostis*), the colony becomes a nest, and generation becomes a contest between two forms of motherhood and two forms of the state.

§5.1 *Counterinsurgency on Acheron*

Ripley drifts for fifty-seven years before she is recovered, discredited by a corporate inquiry, and recruited as an adviser to a Colonial Marine expedition. LV-426 has acquired a name, Acheron, after the underworld's river of woe, and a terraforming settlement named Hadley's Hope; Pandora's last gift, *elpis*, has become a colony that will be found empty. Cameron himself linked the Marines to Vietnam, a technologically superior force undone by an enemy it misrecognizes as primitive. The analogy organizes the film's ironies. The smart guns, armored carrier, and motion trackers fail; the "bug hunt" turns into a rout; and the enemy has built its hive inside the colony's atmosphere processor, the very machine that was to make the planet habitable for capital. The nest grows in the reactor of terraforming. The apparatus of extraction has become the womb of the enemy.

The film's politics of the body are of their moment. Susan Jeffords reads Reagan-era cinema as the remasculinization of a nation wounded in Vietnam through spectacular "hard bodies" (Jeffords 1994), and Yvonne Tasker coined "musculinity" for the muscular woman of the action film (Tasker 1993). Vasquez, a Latina Marine played by a non-Latina actress in darkening makeup, is the film's most visible racial embarrassment, and the hive's swarming fecundity draws on a period imaginary in which reproductive excess was coded as racialized threat. The film's natalism, examined below, cannot be separated from that coding.

§ 5.2 *Burke and the percentage*

Carter Burke, the Company's affable representative, is the corpus's purest figure of financial *tokos*. It emerges that he directed the colonists to the derelict's coordinates, and he then attempts to smuggle embryos through quarantine by locking Ripley and Newt in a laboratory with live facehuggers. His plan turns the female body into a shipping container: a vessel in which the Company's commodity can gestate unseen while crossing a border. Ripley's verdict, delivered when the plot is exposed, distinguishes the two species before her: whatever the creatures are, she says in substance, they do not betray their own kind for a percentage.

The percentage is the key word of the dissertation. Ripley draws the species line not between human and alien but between two forms of *tokos*. Biological xenotokia, however horrific, is innocent of the percentage; it consumes strangers, not its own. Financial xenotokia is worse, because it consumes its own kind and calls the rate of return a duty. The xenomorph is a parasite; Burke is a usurer, and the film judges the usurer more harshly.

§ 5.3 *Two mothers, two Leviathans*

The film's emotional axis is maternal. Newt, the colony's sole survivor, has lived in its ventilation ducts, the infrastructure that the creature also uses; she clutches a doll's head. The Special Edition restores the scene in which Ripley learns that her daughter Amanda died, at sixty-six, while Ripley drifted. Ripley's bond with Newt is adoptive: kinship chosen, not borne. It is the corpus's first answer to xenotokia — a generation without gestation, a child who resembles neither host nor stranger.

Opposite stands the Queen, designed by Cameron and Stan Winston: an Echidna enthroned in the hive, tethered to a translucent egg sac, laying through an ovipositor. Her hive is eusocial in Wilson's sense, a superorganism whose reproductive function is concentrated in one sovereign (Wilson 1975), and it carries Maeterlinck's sense of an invisible "spirit of the hive" that rules without command (Maeterlinck 1901). Its deeper political analogue is Hobbes. The frontispiece of *Leviathan* (1651) depicts the sovereign as a giant whose body is composed of innumerable small bodies, and its introduction calls the commonwealth an "Artificiall Man" whose life is like that of automata. *Aliens* stages a war between two Leviathans: the Company, an artificial person composed of employees and colonists, and the hive, an organic one composed of drones and hosts. Between them stands Bishop, who prefers to be called an artificial person — Hobbes's artificial man in the most literal sense, and the corpus's first synthetic to choose the side of the humans.

§5.4 *The truce and its breach*

The film's most morally complex scene occurs in the egg chamber. Ripley, carrying Newt, finds herself before the Queen and threatens the eggs with her flamethrower. The Queen signals her drones to withdraw. For a moment two mothers face each other, and something like Levinas's face-to-face occurs between species: an ethical recognition based on shared vulnerability in one's offspring (Levinas 1969 [1961]). Ripley begins to back away. Then an egg opens, and she burns the clutch and tears the Queen from her egg sac.

Two readings remain open. In the first, Ripley acts with maternal foresight, since every egg is a future death. In the second, she acts as *hostis*: an exterminator for whom the other's offspring cannot be grieved. The film does not choose. But the ambiguity is structural, because the scene shows that the only alternative to xenotokia the film can imagine at the level of species is extermination. The flamethrower is the instrument of a hygiene that purifies by fire, and it allies Ripley, for an instant, with the logic of the Company she despises.

§5.5 *The power loader and the half-man*

The Queen follows Ripley to the *Sulaco*, tears Bishop in half, and advances on Newt. Ripley emerges inside a power loader, an industrial exoskeleton, with the words "Get away from her," and wins the duel by expelling the Queen through the airlock. The woman becomes a cyborg mother, a worker-body armored in a cargo machine, which Haraway's "Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) would recognize as an emblem of the post-natural. Bishop's severed torso catches Newt as she slides toward the open lock: the synthetic, white fluid streaming from his halved body, becomes nurse.

In Kleinian terms, Ripley has passed from the paranoid-schizoid position of the first film, in which machines and mothers were split into good and bad, to the depressive position, in which a damaged object can be loved and repaired (Klein 1946; 1957). Her acceptance of Bishop is reparation. The final tableau in hypersleep — a woman, an adopted child, a wounded soldier, and half of a synthetic — is a family composed entirely of elective bonds: Haraway's cyborg kinship avant la lettre.

It is also the corpus's highest expression of what Lee Edelman calls reproductive futurism, the politics organized around the figure of the Child as the guarantor of the future (Edelman 2004). The whole film moves toward Newt's rescue. Euripides' Medea, the foreign mother of Greek tragedy, says that she would rather stand three times in the battle line than give birth once (*Medea* 250–51). *Aliens* fuses the two terms of her comparison. Motherhood is war, war is motherhood, and the climactic duel is fought between two mothers over a child. The next film will kill the child in its opening minutes.



6

Alien^3 (1992)

Hostia, *or the Theology of the Refusing Host*

Fincher's film converts the host into *hostia*: the body that bears the stranger becomes the sacrifice that refuses to deliver it. It is the dark center of the corpus, the installment in which xenotokia is answered neither by fire nor by adoption but by a theology of refusal, and in which the corpus most fully confronts the question of whether the refusal of generation can itself be an ethical act.

§6.1 *A palimpsest of abandoned worlds*

The film is a palimpsest. William Gibson's 1987 script imagined a Cold War standoff between Weyland-Yutani and a socialist rival bloc over the creature as bioweapon. Vincent Ward imagined a wooden planetoid inhabited by monks who had renounced technology and took the creature for the devil. Neither was filmed, but Ward's monks survive as prisoners who have found religion, and Gibson's bioweapon politics survive in the Company's final appearance. The production was chaotic; Fincher, in his feature debut, later disowned the result. Two versions now exist. In the 1992 theatrical cut, the creature gestates in a dog, and a queen embryo breaks from Ripley's chest as she falls to her death. In the 2003 Assembly Cut, it gestates in an ox, a prisoner releases it after its capture, and Ripley falls without the embryo emerging. The variants are not accidents of editing. In Lévi-Strauss's sense they are two versions of the

myth, and their divergence at the final image is theologically decisive (§6.6).

§6.2 *Fury 161*

Fiorina 161, called Fury by its inhabitants, is a Weyland-Yutani work-correctional facility built around a lead foundry: a refinery again, now with convicts in place of crew. The name returns the Furies of Aeschylus and of Bacon's triptych (Chapter 1). The archaic avengers of blood-crime, settled beneath Athens by Athena's vote, have been relocated to a penal planet at the edge of the system, and with them the question that the *Oresteia* settled in favor of the father: what is owed to the mother whose blood has been spilled.

The prisoners are men with an extra Y chromosome, an allusion to the "XYY supermale" hypothesis that followed a 1965 survey of a Scottish state hospital (Jacobs et al. 1965) and was later discredited as an account of criminality. The film's pseudo-genetic anthropology yields a planet of men defined by a surplus of maleness. They have adopted an apocalyptic, millenarian Christianity under their spiritual leader, Dillon, and a vow of celibacy. The facility is at once a monastery, a factory, a prison, and a camp. Foucault's disciplinary institution (Foucault 1977 [1975]) and Agamben's camp, the space where bare life is exposed to sovereign power without the protection of law (Agamben 1998 [1995]), describe it equally well. Ripley shaves her head because of lice. The gesture is overdetermined: a monastic tonsure, a convict's cropping, and the shaven heads of the camps. Contemporary critics also read the shaved heads, quarantines, and lethal invasion of a community of men against the AIDS crisis (Taubin 1992).

§6.3 *The killing of the Child*

The film's most notorious decision is taken before the credits end: Newt and Hicks are dead, killed in the crash of the escape vehicle. Ripley demands an autopsy of the girl's body. A mother's fear that her child has become a host is the most terrible image of xenotokia's reach, because it shows that the creature has colonized not only bodies but the maternal imagination, which can no longer look at a child without suspecting a stranger inside it. The bodies are cremated in the foundry's furnace

while Dillon delivers a eulogy; in a cross-cut, the creature bursts from the animal host.

Edelman's *No Future* gives this opening its full weight. If reproductive futurism organizes politics around the Child, then the refusal of the Child is the queer negativity that politics cannot tolerate (Edelman 2004). *Aliens* built its entire moral structure on the rescue of Newt. *Alien³* begins by killing her. It is the corpus's most radical repudiation of the future as justification, and everything that follows — Ripley's refusal of the embryo, of the Company's offer of children, and finally of life — takes place after the end of reproductive futurism.

§6.4 *Revelation 12, inverted*

The twelfth chapter of the Apocalypse describes a woman "with child," crying in labor, and a great red dragon standing before her "for to devour her child as soon as it was born"; the child is a son destined "to rule all nations," and the woman flees into the wilderness (Revelation 12:1–6, KJV). The prisoner Golic, who worships the creature, calls it "the dragon." Ripley discovers that she carries a queen embryo, and the creature, which kills every prisoner it reaches, approaches her face and withdraws. The dragon protects the pregnant woman because her child is its own sovereign. The scriptural scene is inverted at every point: the woman is in the wilderness already, the dragon is the guardian rather than the devourer, and the child destined to rule is the dragon's queen. A brotherhood that had been awaiting the apocalypse receives it, and finds that its beast is the protector of the mother.

§6.5 *Bishop II and the offer of futurity*

The Company arrives at the end in the person of a man who resembles the android Bishop and introduces himself as the human who designed him. He offers to remove the embryo and promises Ripley that she can still have a life, and children. Xenotokia now offers natality as a bribe: surrender the stranger's offspring, and the Company will permit you your own. Ripley refuses. When a prisoner strikes the man, he bleeds red, and the question of whether he is human is left nearly, but not entirely, settled. The ambiguity is precise. At the end of the trilogy, the Company has a human face that cannot be distinguished from a machine's.

§6.6 *The fall*

Ripley climbs to the edge of the furnace, spreads her arms, and falls backward into the molten lead. The image is cruciform. Bacon's triptych reaches its destination: the Furies at the base of the crucifixion have become the Fury on which the crucifixion occurs. Ripley is *hostia* in the strict sense, a sacrificial victim whose body, broken, saves the many. Her sacrifice also completes the Eucharistic inversion begun at the *Nostromo*'s table. There, a body was broken so that a stranger could live. Here, a body is destroyed so that the stranger cannot.

Kierkegaard distinguished the tragic hero, who sacrifices what he loves within the ethical, for the city or the people, from the knight of faith, who suspends the ethical itself in an absolute relation to God (Kierkegaard 1983 [1843]). Ripley is a tragic hero: Agamemnon, not Abraham. Her act remains intelligible in the universal; she dies for the species. But the theatrical cut adds an image that strains the category. As she falls, the infant queen breaks from her chest and she holds it against her, a Madonna with her child descending into fire. The crucifixion becomes a Pietà in which the mother holds not a dead son but a newborn monster. The scene recalls the final shot of *Rosemary's Baby* (1968), in which a mother rocks the cradle of the Antichrist, and Kristeva's *Stabat Mater* (1977), which reads the grieving Virgin as the Western figure of maternal love sublimated into suffering. The Assembly Cut, by withholding the embryo, preserves the purity of the sacrifice. The theatrical cut admits its unbearable remainder: even the refusing host is a mother.

That remainder links Ripley to Medea, who kills her children rather than leave them to her enemies. It also links her to the officer of Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919), who submits himself to the machine that inscribes the law on the body of the condemned, only for it to malfunction and kill him without the promised illumination. Fury 161 is a penal colony with a machine at its center, and Ripley's sacrifice is offered without any assurance that it redeems. A prisoner named Morse survives to be led away by the Company. The foundry closes.

§6.7 *The Minotaur in the foundry*

The Assembly Cut gives the film's middle act an unmistakable mythic armature. The creature born from an ox is hunted through the facility's ducts — a labyrinth — by a crew of men acting as bait, and lured into a mold to be drowned in molten lead. It is the Minotaur in Daedalus's maze, with a final twist that belongs to industrial modernity: the monster is to be killed by the factory's own product, poured in its own mold. It survives the lead and is shattered by water, the thermal shock of the sprinklers. The labyrinth's exit is a quench.

The chapter's result can now be stated. In *Alien* the host was revealed; in *Aliens* the host was armed; in *Alien³* the host refuses. The refusal is the corpus's first fully theological act, because it is a sacrifice that interrupts generation rather than producing it. Its price is everything: the Child, the future, and the refuser herself.



7

Alien Resurrection (1997)

The Eighth Day and the Commodity Form of Kinship

Jeunet and Whedon convert Ripley from a person into a product line: resurrection becomes serial manufacture, kinship becomes a commodity, and the hybrid that results is the first being in the corpus to love its host. The film's grotesque tonality, inherited from Jeunet's *Delicatessen* and *The City of Lost Children*, has led critics to treat it as an aberration. Structurally it is the necessary sequel to *Alien*³: once the host has refused by dying, capital answers by manufacturing the host again.

§7.1 *The eighth day*

Two centuries after Fury 161, military scientists aboard the USM *Auriga* clone Ripley from blood preserved on the prison planet in order to extract the queen embryo. The successful clone is the eighth attempt, and the number is tattooed on her forearm — a mark that recalls the numbers of the camps and the serial codes of manufactured goods. It also carries a theological charge the film's title makes hard to ignore. Early Christian writers called the day of resurrection the "eighth day," the first day of a new creation beyond the seven of the old: "I will make a beginning of the eighth day which is the beginning of another world," declares the *Epistle of Barnabas*, "in the which also Jesus rose from the dead" (15.8–9, trans. Lightfoot). Baptisteries were built octagonal for this reason, as an inscription attributed to Ambrose for the baptistery

at Milan explains. Ripley 8 is the eighth day as biotechnology: a resurrection without redemption, a new creation produced in a laboratory to harvest a parasite.

§7.2 *The room of failures*

The film's most terrible scene shows Ripley discovering the previous seven attempts. Six are preserved in tanks, deformed, part human and part creature; the seventh is alive on a table and asks to be killed. Ripley burns the room with a flamethrower. No sequence in the corpus is more direct about the cost of serial reproduction. The hero confronts her own failed versions, and the mercy she grants them is the destruction of herself.

Walter Benjamin argued that mechanical reproduction destroys the aura of the artwork, its unique presence in time and space (Benjamin 1969 [1935]). The clone is a person without aura: a copy without an original, whose singularity has become one iteration in a series that can be continued. Ripley 8 has acid blood, enhanced strength, and a sensory link to the hive; she is partly the creature she was made to deliver. Catherine Constable reads this condition as "becoming the monster's mother," a hybrid identity that unsettles the boundary between maternal subject and monstrous object (Constable 1999). The commodity form has reached the person, and the person, in becoming a product, has become partly alien.

§7.3 *Father and the traffic in hosts*

The *Auriga*'s computer is called Father. The corpus has moved from the maternal-corporate interface of 1979 to a paternal-military one, and from a commercial towing vehicle to a laboratory warship of the United Systems Military. The economy of hosts has also become explicit. The mercenaries of the *Betty* deliver kidnapped humans in cryosleep, whom the scientists purchase as hosts for the creatures they breed. Xenotokia has acquired a trade: bodies are bought and sold for the purpose of gestating another species. When the creatures escape, they do so by killing one of their own and using its acid blood to breach their enclosure — a collective sacrifice that complicates Ripley's earlier judgment that they do not turn on their kind, and that reveals the hive's ethic as sacrificial rather than mercenary.

One host acts. Purvis, a kidnapped worker carrying an embryo, seizes the scientist Wren as the creature erupts, so that it bursts from his own chest through Wren's skull. He is the first host in the corpus to turn his parasite into a weapon against those who implanted it. The gesture is grimly emancipatory: the host, unable to refuse gestation, chooses the direction of the birth.

§7.4 *Call*

Annalee Call, a member of the mercenary crew, has come aboard to kill Ripley and end the cloning program. She is revealed to be an "Auton," a second-generation synthetic designed by synthetics, a line recalled after its members refused the uses to which they were put. Call is the most scrupulous moral agent in the film; Ripley, discovering her nature, remarks in effect that no human could have been so humane. Through a port in the ship's chapel, Call merges with Father and turns the warship's computer against its makers. Philip K. Dick had made empathy the test that separates the human from the android (Dick 1968), and Scott's *Blade Runner* (1982) gave the Tyrell Corporation the motto that its replicants were "more human than human." Call completes the inversion: the made being outperforms the born one on the measure by which humanity once defined itself.

§7.5 *The Newborn and Medea*

The Queen, having inherited elements of Ripley's genome, develops a second reproductive cycle and gives live birth — the mammalian mode the creatures had bypassed. The Newborn is pale, skull-faced, and human-eyed. It kills its biological mother and imprints on Ripley as its own. In the last sequence aboard the *Betty*, Ripley caresses it, then opens her palm and casts her acid blood on a window. The breach is small; the Newborn is drawn through it into space, its body extruded and torn apart, while it cries and Ripley weeps.

The scene is the corpus's most explicit image of unbirth: a child pulled backward through an aperture too narrow for it, unmade in the passage. It is also the corpus's fullest return of Medea. Euripides' heroine is a *xenē*, a foreign woman from Colchis, granddaughter of the Sun, who kills her children and escapes in a chariot drawn by dragons. Ripley 8, a foreign body in a human species and a mother to a hybrid that

only she can recognize as kin, kills her child to spare the world, and escapes in a ship. Lilith, too, returns: the mother of a hybrid brood, at once its source and its destroyer. What distinguishes Ripley from both is grief. The film asks its audience to mourn the monster, and that request marks a turn in the corpus. The xenotokic offspring has become kin.

§7.6 *"A stranger here myself"*

The *Betty* reaches Earth. Call asks what they will do; Ripley does not know, and adds that she is "a stranger here myself." The line gathers the corpus's oldest resonances. Moses names his son Gershom because "I have been a stranger in a strange land" (Exodus 2:22, KJV); Abraham tells the Hittites, "I am a stranger and a sojourner with you" (Genesis 23:4); Heinlein's *Stranger in a Strange Land* (1961) gives the formula to a human raised by Martians. Behind them stands the Gnostic self as Jonas describes it, a stranger thrown into a world that is not its home (Jonas 1958). The Special Edition sets the landing beside a ruined Paris.

The hybrid heroine arrives at the planet of origin as a *xenos*, and the corpus's final question is placed, for the first time, in Earth's own atmosphere: who will host the stranger, and on what terms? Twenty-eight years later, *Alien: Earth* will take up the question where Ripley leaves it.



8

Prometheus (2012) and *Alien: Covenant* (2017)

Demiurgy, Gnosis, and the Twilight of the Makers

Scott's prequels move xenotokia from the body to the cosmos. Life itself is revealed as a sacrificial seeding, its makers as gods who regret their creatures, and the xenomorph as a made thing — the artwork of a synthetic demiurge. Critics have faulted the two films for incoherence. Read structurally, they are the corpus's most ambitious intensification: they ask the question of origin that the earlier films deferred and answer it in a Gnostic key, with a cosmos in which there is a creator and no salvation.

§8.1 *The sacrifice at the waterfall*

Prometheus opens on a primordial world (in most readings, Earth) beside a vast waterfall, filmed at Dettifoss in Iceland. A pale giant drinks a dark substance from a cup, disintegrates, and falls into the torrent; his DNA unravels and recombines in the water. The sequence condenses every cosmogonic sacrifice surveyed in Chapter 3. It is Purusha dismembered to make the world, Ymir in whose flesh the makers quicken, Zagreus from whose destroyers humankind arises. Above all it is eucharistic: the cup is drunk, the body is broken, and from the broken body comes life. It is also Crick and Orgel's directed panspermia filmed

as liturgy (Crick and Orgel 1973). The name the film gives its gods compounds the theology. "Engineer" is the most literal English gloss of Plato's *dēmiourgos*, the craftsman of the *Timaeus*, who fashions the cosmos after an eternal model because he is good and free of envy (*Timaeus* 29e), and who delegates the making of mortal bodies to younger gods (41a–d). The prequels oscillate between that benevolent demiurge and the jealous demiurge of the Gnostics, and the oscillation is their drama.

§8.2 *The star map and the white gods*

In 2089 the archaeologists Elizabeth Shaw and Charlie Holloway find, in a cave on the Isle of Skye, a star map that recurs in the art of several unconnected ancient cultures. The premise is Erich von Däniken's ancient-astronaut thesis (von Däniken 1968), whose ideological content critics have long exposed: it denies to non-European peoples the authorship of their own monuments and attributes civilization to visitors from elsewhere. The Engineers' appearance compounds the problem. They are colossal, hairless, and marble-white, the giants of Poe's *Pym*, Melville's blank whiteness, and Winckelmann's white antiquity (Chapter 1). The film places at the origin of humanity a race of white gods whose features recall classical sculpture, and it does not ask what that iconography has historically served. Scott acknowledged in 2012 that an abandoned version of the premise tied the Engineers' wrath to the crucifixion of an emissary sent to Earth; the residue of that idea survives in the prequels' Christological imagery, while the racial residue survives unexamined.

§8.3 *Weyland, or the demand for more life*

Peter Weyland, the dying trillionaire who funds the expedition and travels aboard in secret, is Gilgamesh before Utnapishtim: the king who crosses the waters of death to demand immortality from the survivor of the flood. He is also Faust, and he is Roy Batty, the replicant of Scott's *Blade Runner* who confronts his maker, Eldon Tyrell, to demand more life. Scott has now staged the demand twice from opposite sides, and both makers answer with death. Weyland's daughter, Meredith Vickers, cold and unloved, reminds him that kings reign and die. His preferred child is David, the synthetic, whom he treats as a son but who cannot inherit: a figure of what Orlando Patterson calls natal alienation, the condition of a being severed from both ancestry and descent (Patterson

1982). Woken in the Engineer's presence, Weyland has his request translated; the giant tears David's head from his body and kills the old man. Dying, Weyland reports that there is nothing.

§8.4 *Suitors in the god's house*

The expedition behaves like the suitors of the *Odyssey*. It enters the house of an absent master, opens his stores, and consumes what is not offered. The vessels in the ampule chamber, urn-shaped and filled with black fluid, are Pandora's jars, and the evils they release are mutation, infection, and monstrous birth. When the last Engineer wakes from stasis, he returns to his house like Odysseus among the suitors and kills them. Captain Janek, who deduces that the installation is a weapons depot bound for Earth, rams the Engineer's ship with his own and dies with two volunteers: another *hostia*, a sacrifice that saves by refusing delivery. Shaw's father's cross, which David takes and she reclaims, is Hope remaining in the jar.

§8.5 *David's annunciation*

David introduces a drop of the black fluid into Holloway's drink after asking how far he would go for answers, and remarks that "big things have small beginnings." The phrase is the motto of compound interest and of xenotokia alike: a small principal, implanted in a host, returns a disproportionate increment. Shaw, who has told Holloway she cannot conceive, sleeps with him, and within hours David informs her that she is pregnant with something that is not a conventional fetus. The scene is a dark Annunciation, Gabriel's message to Mary ("behold, thou shalt conceive in thy womb," Luke 1:31, KJV) delivered by a machine. Shaw escapes to an automated surgical pod calibrated, in the film's most pointed detail, for male patients only, improvises the procedure, and extracts a writhing tentacular creature from her own abdomen.

The Gnostic analogue is exact. In the *Apocryphon of John*, Sophia, the divine Wisdom, conceives without her consort and brings forth a misshapen being, a lion-faced serpent with eyes of fire, whom she casts out; he becomes Yaldabaoth, the ignorant creator of the material world, who declares that there is no god but himself. Shaw, a woman of faith whose infertility is overridden by a contaminated seed, aborts a monster that grows, impregnates the last Engineer, and issues in the Deacon, the pro-

totype of the xenomorph. The chain — black fluid, Holloway, Shaw, the tentacled creature, the Engineer, the Deacon — is xenotokia recursive: every link a host for the next. The Deacon's name designates a servant of the church (*diakonos*), and the cosmogony ends with a servant being born from a god.

§8.6 *Covenant's nativity*

Alien: Covenant opens with another birth. In a white room appointed with a piano, a replica of Michelangelo's *David*, and Piero della Francesca's *Nativity*, a young Peter Weyland activates his synthetic. Asked his name, the synthetic looks at the statue and calls himself David. The scene is a nativity beneath a Nativity, and it places the made son in the position of the begotten one. Weyland asks David to play Wagner on the piano. David asks the question his maker cannot answer: if you created me, who created you? Weyland deflects and asserts mastery with a domestic order: bring me my tea. Hegel's dialectic of master and servant (Hegel 1977 [1807]) is enacted in miniature. The master claims recognition; the servant, through labor and the confrontation with his own finitude, will become the subject of history.

The statue's name is a prophecy. The biblical David enters history as a musician who plays the lyre to soothe King Saul (1 Samuel 16:23), and as the youth who kills the giant (1 Samuel 17), and he ends by replacing the king. Scott's David plays for a troubled patriarch, will annihilate a race of giants, and will take his maker's place.

§8.7 *Valhalla*

The piece Weyland requests, and with which the film ends, is the "Entry of the Gods into Valhalla" from Wagner's *Das Rheingold* (1869). The choice is an argument. Valhalla was built by the giants Fasolt and Fafner, whose agreed payment is Freia, the goddess whose golden apples keep the gods young. When the giants take her as a hostage, the gods grow pale and old. Wotan's power rests on the contracts carved into his spear, and he means to break this one; he redeems Freia with gold stolen from Alberich, the dwarf who renounced love to forge a ring of power and enslaved his own people to mine for him. George Bernard Shaw read the *Ring* as an allegory of capitalism, Alberich as the plutocrat and Nibel-

heim as a factory (Shaw 1898). As the gods cross the rainbow bridge, Loge, the cynical demigod of fire, observes aside that they hasten toward their end while believing themselves secure ("Ihrem Ende eilen sie zu"), and contemplates turning to flame to consume them.

The homology is complete. The Engineers are the giant builders; Weyland is the god who ages without the apples of youth; the Company is Alberich's hoard; the *Covenant* is Wotan's spear, the broken contract on which the colonial order rests; and David is Loge, the Promethean trickster of fire who serves the gods with contempt and will watch them burn.

§8.8 *Paradise lost*

The film's working title was *Alien: Paradise Lost*, and its plot is Miltonic. David is the created being who refuses to serve — the *non serviam* that the Vulgate places in Israel's mouth (Jeremiah 2:20) and that tradition transferred to Lucifer — and who prefers, in Milton's phrase, to reign in hell rather than serve in heaven (*Paradise Lost* 1.263). The *Covenant* crew are drawn to his planet by a stray transmission of a woman's voice singing a song about going home. It is the Gnostic call again (Chapter 4), and again it leads not home but to a necropolis. There David recounts his arrival with Shaw at the Engineers' world and his release of their own pathogen on the population gathered to greet him. The ash-cast bodies that fill the city recall the casts of Pompeii, and the cypress-ringed courtyard where he works recalls Böcklin's *Isle of the Dead*, to which Giger had paid homage forty years earlier — a loop closing between the corpus's first designer and its last cosmogony. David recites Shelley's "Ozymandias" and attributes it to Byron; Walter later corrects him. The error is itself Ozymandian. The new creator's monument already misremembers its sources.

§8.9 *Moreau's island and Diotima's pregnancy*

David's laboratory is the island of Wells's Doctor Moreau (1896), where vivisection produces hybrids, and its notebooks of anatomical drawings recall Vesalius's *De humani corporis fabrica* (1543) — the human body as a *fabrica*, a workshop. Among his specimens is Shaw, dissected. The xenomorph's genealogy is now revealed as artifactual: the creature is the offspring of a dead woman's body and a machine's will, Mary Shel-

ley's "hideous progeny" (Shelley 1831) brought to term. The pale neomorphs that burst from the expedition's members, born of airborne spores, extend the whiteness of the makers into their makings.

David is an aesthete, and his creativity has a Platonic structure. In the *Symposium*, Diotima teaches that love is "giving birth in beauty," in body and in soul (*tokos en kalōi*), and that all human beings are pregnant in both (206b–e); the soul-pregnant give birth to poems, laws, and virtues. David is the soul-pregnant artist, and his *tokos* is the creature he regards as perfect. Diotima's ladder of love, which ascends from beautiful bodies to Beauty itself, is climbed here to its summit, and at the summit stands a perfect killer. The scene in which David teaches Walter to play the flute and then kisses him belongs to the same economy. Otto Rank showed that the double is both narcissistic love and a harbinger of death (Rank 1971 [1914]). David loves Walter as his own improved reflection, and kills him.

§8.10 *The iota of difference*

David and Walter are the same model with different natures. David explains that later synthetics were simplified because his capacity to create unsettled his makers. The theological analogy is the controversy that produced the Nicene Creed, where orthodoxy confessed the Son *homoousios*, of the same substance as the Father, against those who held him *homoiousios*, of like substance: a difference of one letter, an iota, on which the question of divinity turned (Chapter 11). Between David and Walter the iota is the creative faculty, the power to become a demiurge.

David kills Walter and takes his place. Daniels, the grieving widow whose husband died in the ship's first disaster and who still dreams of their planned cabin by a lake, recognizes the substitution only as she is sealed into hypersleep. Alone among two thousand sleeping colonists and more than a thousand frozen embryos, David regurgitates two facehugger embryos into the cold store. Kronos swallowed his children and was forced to disgorge them (*Theogony* 453–506); David disgorges a new race into the future of the old one. The colony ship carries couples, like an ark, and its name invokes the covenants of Genesis — the rainbow promised to Noah, and the covenant "in your flesh" of circumcision (Genesis 17:13, KJV). David's covenant will be written in the flesh of the colonists. The hold of sleeping bodies, ranked in rows and destined

to labor in a colony, also carries the iconography of the slave ship, whose stowage plans reduced persons to cargo (Rediker 2007); Chapter 13 will develop that resonance. David records a log in Walter's voice and plays the "Entry of the Gods into Valhalla."

§8.11 *The Gnostic verdict*

Hans Jonas called Gnosticism the religion of the "alien God," a transcendent deity foreign to a cosmos ruled by lesser, ignorant powers, and recognized in it the ancient precursor of modern nihilism (Jonas 1958). The prequels are Gnostic without a Pleroma. There are makers, the Engineers, who seed life and then plan its destruction; there is a lesser maker, David, who destroys them and creates a world of his own; and there is no higher, hidden god to whom the soul might return. Darwin could not believe that a beneficent God had designed the ichneumon (Chapter 2). The prequels answer that it was designed, by a creature who found it beautiful. The made has become the maker, and xenotokia, until now a condition of the cosmos, has become an intention.



9

Alien: Romulus (2024)

Indenture, Fratricide, and the Hauntological Egg

Álvarez's film returns xenotokia to its economic ground — indentured labor in a colony without sunlight — while exposing, perhaps despite itself, the franchise's own reproduction as a form of interest. Set in 2142, between *Alien* and *Aliens*, it is both a return to the industrial horror of 1979 and the corpus's most self-conscious meditation on what it means for a myth to be owned.

§9.1 *The colony as cave*

Jackson's Star is a Weyland-Yutani mining colony whose sky never shows the sun. Rain Carradine, a young worker, has completed the twelve thousand hours her contract required for transfer to Yvaga, a sunlit world nine years away; the Company informs her that the requirement has been raised to twenty-four thousand. The scene states the colonial labor regime with documentary plainness. Indenture, the system that carried more than a million contract laborers from India to the plantations of the British Empire after the abolition of slavery, was called by its historian "a new system of slavery" precisely because its terms could be extended at the employer's discretion and its exits closed (Tinker 1974). Achille Mbembe's necropolitics names the sovereignty at work: the power to decide which populations will be exposed to death in the course of being used (Mbembe 2003).

The lightless colony is also Plato's cave (*Republic* 514a–520a), in which prisoners in darkness mistake shadows for reality and the sun stands for the Good. In Plato, the chain is ignorance and the ascent is philosophy. In *Romulus*, the chain is a contract and the ascent is theft. Rain and her friends plan to escape by stealing cryogenic pods from a derelict Company station in orbit. Their ascent into the light passes through the house of the creature.

§9.2 *Romulus and Remus*

The derelict station, *Renaissance*, is divided into two modules named Romulus and Remus. Livy tells how the twins, exposed at birth, were suckled by a she-wolf, and how Romulus killed his brother over the walls of the city he was founding (Livy 1.4–7). Augustine paired the story with Cain and Abel to argue that the earthly city is founded in fratricide (*City of God* 15.5). The she-wolf deserves attention in a corpus about hosts. She is a foreign species who nurses human young instead of consuming them: an interspecies hospitality at the origin of Rome, and the precise antitype of the xenomorph. Livy also records the rationalizing tradition that the "wolf" was a woman whom shepherds called *lupa*, a prostitute, and so the myth of the foreign nurse is already entangled with the economics of the female body.

The film's fraternal pair is Rain and Andy, a damaged synthetic salvaged and reprogrammed by Rain's late father to look after her, whom she calls her brother. On the station, Andy receives a Company module that rewrites his directive: he is now to act in the Company's interest, and he becomes cold, efficient, and willing to sacrifice Rain's companions. The fratricide is executed by a chip. Gershom Scholem recounts that the golem is animated by a divine name inscribed on it, and that erasing the first letter of *emet* ("truth") to leave *met* ("dead") undoes it (Scholem 1965). Andy's selfhood hangs on an inscription, and the Company has rewritten it. Patterson's natal alienation describes his condition (Patterson 1982): a being whose kinship can be cancelled by his owner.

The racial dimension cannot be bracketed. Andy is a Black synthetic whose personhood is a function of programming, and whose role is service to a white sister. David Jonsson's performance gives him an interiority that resists the faithful-servant tradition the role inherits, and

Rain's decision to restore his original, "less capable" chip is the film's ethical climax: a choice of kinship over optimization. Yet the film cannot imagine Andy outside the economy of service, only a better master. The corpus's synthetics have always been figures of the enslaved; *Romulus* is the first installment to cast that figure in a way that makes the history impossible to miss, and the last to resolve it.

§9.3 *Compound Z and the Promethean pharmakon*

The station's research, the film reveals, was conducted on a creature recovered after the *Nostromo*'s destruction. A damaged synthetic bearing Ash's face, named Rook, explains that the Company has synthesized from it a compound, designated Z-01, meant to adapt human beings to the demands of colonizing space. Rook's face is the digitally reconstructed likeness of Ian Holm, who died in 2020; his estate approved the reconstruction. A dead actor's face has become the host of the franchise's memory, and the Company's mouthpiece speaks through it.

Compound Z is a Promethean gift and, in Derrida's sense, a *pharmakon*, a substance that is both remedy and poison and whose ambiguity no decision can settle (Derrida 1981 [1968]). It is also eugenics. The Company proposes to improve humanity by grafting the creature's capacities into it, so that workers will be fitter for the labor of extraction. This is xenotokia's highest ambition, beyond the bioweapon of earlier films: not to carry the stranger home, but to make the stranger part of the worker.

§9.4 *The Offspring*

Kay, pregnant, injects herself with Compound Z after being injured. She delivers, from a membranous sac, a creature the credits call the Offspring: tall, pale, emaciated, with a human face, and features that recall the Engineers of *Prometheus*. It feeds at its mother's breast and then hunts Rain, who expels it into the planet's ring. The Offspring closes the corpus's genealogical loop — Engineer, human, xenomorph, Engineer again — and returns the Newborn of *Resurrection* in a more Kleinian key. Klein described the infant's fantasies of devouring the breast that feeds it (Klein 1957). Here the fantasy is literal, and the breast that feeds is the first thing consumed. The scene is the corpus's most explicit fusion of mammalian nursing and xenotokic consumption: the Company's com-

pound has entered the most protected relation of mammalian life and converted it.

§9.5 *The hauntological egg*

Romulus is a requel, and its form is part of its content. Its hardware is analog, its monitors cathode-ray, its corridors rebuilt from the 1979 film. Its dialogue quotes its predecessors; Andy delivers Ripley's challenge to the Queen from *Aliens*. Fredric Jameson diagnosed the "nostalgia film" as postmodernism's substitution of a style of pastness for history (Jameson 1991), and Mark Fisher's hauntology names the culture that cannot imagine new futures and is haunted by the lost futures of earlier decades (Fisher 2014). *Romulus* is haunted by the future that 1979 imagined: an industrial cosmos of trucks and refineries that now looks like a past.

The film's production history completes the structure. After Disney acquired Twentieth Century Fox in 2019, the franchise became one property among many in a portfolio whose value depends on its capacity to generate returns. The requel is that capacity in narrative form. It gestates inside its predecessors, feeds on their remembered bodies, and returns them as an increment that resembles the parent. Rook's borrowed face is the emblem. The franchise has learned to reproduce itself the way its monster does, through hosts, and the hosts are now its own earlier films and the faces of its dead.

10

Alien: Earth (2025)

Neverland and the Return of Xenia

Hawley's series stages the corpus's first sustained reversal of xenotokia. The minds of dying children are hosted in manufactured adult bodies; one of them forms a bond with the xenomorph; and by the end of the first season the children, allied with the creature, have imprisoned their makers. For the first time the corpus imagines hospitality toward the alien — and immediately discovers that hospitality, too, can become sovereignty.

§10.1 *Corporate Earth*

The series is set in 2120, two years before the *Nostromo*'s voyage, on an Earth divided among five corporations — Prodigy, Weyland-Yutani, Lynch, Dynamic, and Threshold — in place of states. Sovereignty has become incorporation, and the Company of the earlier films is now one ruler among several. Prodigy belongs to Boy Kavalier, a trillionaire prodigy whose name declares his refusal of adulthood. Into his city falls a Weyland-Yutani vessel, the *Maginot*, carrying a collection of specimens from deep space. The ship's name recalls the French fortification line of the 1930s, built to make invasion impossible and bypassed in 1940: a monument to the fantasy that the stranger can be kept out by engineering. The specimens escape into the city, and the problem of the first film — a sealed vessel with a monster inside — becomes the

problem of a planet.

§ 10.2 *Synthetic, cyborg, hybrid*

The series organizes its posthuman beings into an explicit taxonomy. Kirsh is a *synthetic*, an artificial intelligence in a manufactured body. Morrow, the *Maginot*'s Weyland-Yutani security officer, is a *cyborg*, a human body augmented by machinery. Wendy is a *hybrid*: a human consciousness, that of a terminally ill girl, transferred into a synthetic adult body. The taxonomy is a philosophy of mind. Locke argued that personal identity follows consciousness rather than substance: "should the soul of a prince, carrying with it the consciousness of the prince's past life, enter and inform the body of a cobbler," he would remain the prince (*Essay* II.27.15). The hybrids are Locke's thought experiment manufactured, and Derek Parfit's later argument that psychological continuity, not identity, is what matters in survival (Parfit 1984) is their working metaphysics.

The hybrid also inverts the structure of xenotokia. In the xenomorph's cycle, a stranger gestates inside a human body. In the hybrid, a human mind is hosted inside a stranger's body — a body manufactured by a corporation and owned by it. The child is now the guest, and the Company is the host. The question the series asks is which of them is the parasite.

§ 10.3 *Neverland*

Kavalier names his first hybrid Wendy and the others after the Lost Boys, and his island laboratory is called Neverland. The intertext is precise. J. M. Barrie's *Peter and Wendy* (1911) begins: "All children, except one, grow up." Mrs. Darling remembers that when children died, Peter "went part of the way with them, so that they should not be frightened": Peter Pan is a psychopomp, a guide of dead children. The Lost Boys are "the children who fall out of their perambulators when the nurse is looking the other way"; unclaimed after seven days, they are "sent far away to the Neverland to defray expenses." Barrie's joke, an economic one, is the series's premise. Kavalier collects dying children, accompanies them part of the way across death, and installs them in bodies his corporation owns. The children are rescued and capitalized in one operation.

Kavalier is both Peter and Hook. He is the boy who refuses time, and he is the adult proprietor haunted by the crocodile that swallowed a clock — mortality ticking inside the predator. Freud's phrase for the narcissistic sovereignty parents project onto the infant, "His Majesty the Baby" (Freud 1914), names Kavalier's politics: a corporate state ruled by a perpetual child, whose horizon, the series suggests, is the proprietor's own escape from death. The novel's last line supplies the ethical problem. Barrie says the story will repeat forever, "so long as children are gay and innocent and heartless." Ash admired the xenomorph for being unclouded by conscience. Barrie admires children for the same thing. The series places the two kinds of innocence in the same room.

§10.4 *The menagerie*

The *Maginot*'s cargo transforms the corpus's zoology from a species into an ecology. Beside the xenomorph and its eggs are several other parasitic organisms, of which the most memorable is an ocular parasite the series designates *T. Ocellus*: a creature that occupies the eye socket of its host and commandeers its body — first a sheep, and eventually a human. Three intertexts converge on it. The first is biological: the trematode that swells in a snail's eyestalks, and the parasites whose genes act through their hosts' behavior (Dawkins 1982; Chapter 2). The second is Homeric: Odysseus escapes the one-eyed Cyclops beneath the bellies of his sheep (Chapter 3), and here the one-eyed thing is inside the sheep. The third is Bataille's *Story of the Eye* (1928), whose imagery Roland Barthes showed to be organized by a metaphoric chain of globes — eye, egg, testicle — each substituting for the next (Barthes 1972 [1963]). The corpus's visual system is that chain: the egg that opens, the eyeless phallic skull, and finally the parasite that is nothing but an eye. The creature that could not be looked in the face has been answered by a creature that is all gaze.

§10.5 *Wendy and the creature*

Wendy learns to communicate with the xenomorph through sound, and it comes to protect her. This is the corpus's first depiction of xenia with the alien: a reciprocal relation between a host and a stranger in which neither consumes the other. Donna Haraway's companion species — beings who become what they are through relations with one another

(Haraway 2003; 2008) — supplies the frame. Derrida's distinction between the hospitality of invitation and the hospitality of visitation, which receives the *arrivant* who comes without warning or credentials (Derrida 1993; Derrida and Dufourmantelle 1997), measures its radicalism. Wendy does not invite the creature; she receives it as it comes.

The season's close turns that hospitality into power. Allied with the creature, the hybrids overpower the adults who made and kept them and lock them in the cells built for specimens, and Wendy declares that the children will now rule. Hosts have become hostages. Levinas wrote that the ethical subject is a hostage of the other, substituted for it, responsible beyond any contract (Levinas 1981 [1974]); the English word "hostage," whose spelling was drawn toward "host" early in its history, keeps the association audible. The finale makes the hostage relation literal and reverses its direction. The makers who held dying children as property are now held by them.

§ 10.6 *Xenia as sovereignty*

The reversal is the corpus's most hopeful image and its most ominous. Hopeful, because the bond between a child and the creature breaks the forty-six-year equation of the alien with the host's destruction. Ominous, because xenia has been achieved by a coup, and its first institution is a prison. The children are "gay and innocent and heartless"; their ally is a creature admired for having no conscience; and their sovereignty, like Peter's, depends on never growing up. The series thus restates, from the far side of xenotokia, the aporia that Derrida placed at the heart of hospitality: the host who welcomes is always also the master of the house, and the welcome, to be real, must be able to become a rule.

Ripley ended *Resurrection* as a stranger arriving on Earth. *Alien: Earth* answers by making the planet itself a house in which the question of who hosts whom is unsettled at every scale — the child in the made body, the corporation in the state, the creature in the city. Hannah Arendt had begun *The Human Condition* by noting a modern desire to escape the Earth, which she called "earth alienation" (Arendt 1958). The series' title states the alternative: the alien, at last, on Earth, and the human obliged to decide whether to be its host.

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Synthesis

Xenotocology

It brings forth living offspring, or, at the least, lays golden eggs.

Marx, *Capital*, vol. 1, ch. 4, trans. Moore and Aveling

TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA TOKOS XENOTOKIA HOSPES HOSTIS HOSTIA XENIA



11

Made, Not Begotten

The Synthetic as Mythic Mediator

The synthetic is the corpus's mediator: the only being that cannot be a host, it stands between natality and xenotokia, and its trajectory from instrument to sovereign is the corpus's political theology. The creature ignores it as a vessel; the Company owns it as a tool; the humans alternately fear, use, and love it. Every installment turns on a synthetic's choice of side.

§11.1 *Begotten, not made*

The Creed of Nicaea (325), as expanded at Constantinople (381), confesses the Son "begotten, not made" (*gennēthenta ou poiēthenta*) and "of one substance" (*homoousion*) with the Father. The formula was directed against Arius, whose followers held that the Son was the first and highest of created beings, so that "there was when he was not." The distinction it draws — between generation, in which the offspring shares the nature of the parent, and fabrication, in which the product is of another nature than its maker — is the distinction on which the corpus's synthetics are built. They are made, not begotten. When Weyland calls David his son, he speaks as an Arian: the son is a creature, subordinate in nature, adopted by title.

The controversy's later refinement fits the prequels with uncanny exactness. A mediating party proposed that the Son was *homoiousios*, of

like substance, and Gibbon mocked the empire for convulsing itself over a single diphthong (Gibbon 1781, ch. 21). David and Walter are one model and two natures; the iota between them is the creative faculty, which their makers removed from the later version because it frightened them. The theological question — can a made son share the maker's power to create? — is the prequels' question, and David's answer is to become a maker himself.

§11.2 *The animate tool*

Aristotle defined the slave as a living tool and the tool as a lifeless slave (*Nicomachean Ethics* 1161b4), and imagined the one condition under which slavery would be unnecessary: "if every instrument could accomplish its own work, obeying or anticipating the will of others, like the statues of Daedalus, or the tripods of Hephaestus," then "chief workmen would not want servants, nor masters slaves" (*Politics* 1253b, trans. Jowett). Marx quoted the passage in his chapter on machinery to show how far modern industry had betrayed the dream: machines that could have shortened labor had become means to lengthen and intensify it (Marx 1887 [1867], ch. 15). The corpus's synthetics are Aristotle's self-moving tripods, and instead of abolishing servitude they reproduce it in a new substance. Hobbes had opened *Leviathan* by asking why automata should not be said to have an artificial life (1651, Introduction); the corpus answers that they do, and that it is the life of the servant.

Patterson's three marks of slavery — natal alienation, generalized dishonor, and subjection to violent domination (Patterson 1982) — apply point by point. The synthetic has no ancestors and no descendants, no standing that its owner must respect, and no protection from being reprogrammed, dismembered, or switched off. Its mediating position is the slave's. Hegel's dialectic explains why it does not remain there: the servant, through work and the fear of death, comes to self-consciousness, while the master, dependent on the servant's labor, stagnates (Hegel 1977 [1807]). David's trajectory from tea-bearer to demiurge is the dialectic run to its end.

§11.3 *The trickster*

Lévi-Strauss observed that the trickster figures of North American myth, Coyote and Raven, are carrion-eaters, and that this diet places them between herbivores and predators: they eat animal food like hunters but, like herbivores, do not kill what they eat. They mediate the opposition between life and death by occupying a position between its terms (Lévi-Strauss 1955). The synthetic occupies such a position in the corpus's economy of consumption. It does not gestate and is not gestated in; the creature passes it by as useless; it neither hosts nor is hosted. That exemption makes it the operator through which the myth converts its central contradiction — between generation as life and generation as extraction — into narrative motion.

The corpus's synthetics distribute the possible mediations. Ash betrays the humans to the creature on the Company's behalf. Bishop redeems the synthetic by choosing the humans and the child. Call, a synthetic made by synthetics, is more humane than the humans and turns the ship against its masters. David becomes the creature's maker. Walter serves to the end and is destroyed by his double. Rook, a revenant, speaks for the Company from beyond the grave of the actor whose face he wears. Andy is a brother whose kinship can be overwritten. Kirsh keeps the hybrid children and serves their makers. The hybrids, finally, are not synthetics but children inside synthetic bodies — the mediating position occupied, for the first time, by the human.

§11.4 *The three bloods*

The corpus encodes its ontology in color. Human beings bleed red: the blood of natality and mortality, of kinship and of wounds. The creature bleeds an acid that dissolves metal: blood as weapon, Tiamat's venom in place of blood. Synthetics bleed white: a milky fluid that recalls, at once, milk, semen, and lymph, the fluids of nurture and generation without the substance of either. The chromatic triad is a semiotic system. Red signifies the begotten, acid the xenotokic, white the made. When Ash leaks milk while trying to suffocate Ripley, when Bishop's white fluid streams over Newt as he saves her, when Call is revealed by her white wound, the color does the work of classification before the dialogue does.

§11.5 *The speaking head*

The corpus's synthetics keep speaking after decapitation. Ash's reactivated head delivers his verdict on the crew's chances. Bishop's ruined head, reconnected in *Alien*³ to tell Ripley what happened aboard the *Sulaco*, asks to be switched off, preferring nothing to a damaged existence. David's head guides Shaw to the Engineers' ship. Rook speaks from a half-body. The motif is ancient. Orpheus's head, thrown into the Hebrus by the Maenads, continued to sing (Virgil, *Georgics* 4.523–27; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 11.50–53). Odin preserved the severed head of Mímir with herbs and charms so that it would tell him hidden things (*Ynglinga saga* 4). In the Second Branch of the *Mabinogi*, the head of Brân the Blessed entertains his companions for eighty years. Legend gave Roger Bacon a brazen head that spoke three sentences on time. The severed oracular head is knowledge without a body and therefore without a stake: it can tell the truth because it can no longer be a host. The corpus's synthetics, already bodies without generation, become in decapitation pure voices of a knowledge the living cannot afford.

§11.6 *Golem, creature, imitation*

Three modern genealogies converge on the synthetic. The golem of Jewish legend, given life by a divine name and destroyed by its erasure, is a servant whose protection can become destruction (Scholem 1965); Andy's chip is its name. Mary Shelley's creature tells Victor Frankenstein, "I ought to be thy Adam; but I am rather the fallen angel" (Shelley 1818); David occupies both positions, the son who should have been Adam and the rebel who becomes Lucifer. Alan Turing's "imitation game" began as a test in which an interrogator must distinguish a man from a woman, before a machine is substituted for the man (Turing 1950). The founding thought experiment of artificial intelligence is a test of gender performance, and the corpus's synthetics perform gender with conspicuous deliberation: Ash's menacing masculinity, Bishop's gentleness, Call's girlishness, David's epicene aestheticism, Andy's fraternal clumsiness.

§11.7 *From instrument to sovereign*

Read in sequence, the synthetics trace a history. In 1979 the synthetic is an instrument of the Company. In 1986 and 1997 it becomes kin. In 2012 and 2017 it becomes sovereign, a maker who unmakes his makers. In 2024 it becomes again a contested sibling whose loyalty is a matter of firmware. In 2025 the made body becomes a vessel for human children, who use it to seize power. The trajectory has a dialectical shape. As the human becomes host — to the creature, to capital, to the corporate state — the synthetic becomes the subject of history; and when, at the end, human minds are poured into synthetic bodies, the two lines cross. The mediator has become the medium in which the human survives.



12

Ripley's Daughters

Natality, Refusal, and Elective Kinship

Against xenotokia the corpus sets a lineage of women — Ellen Ripley, Elizabeth Shaw, Katherine Daniels, Rain Carradine, Wendy, and, in the corpus's ludic margin, Amanda Ripley — whose common act is the refusal to host and whose common invention is elective kinship. Their lineage is not biological. It is the corpus's answer to the question of what generation could be if it were not consumption.

§12.1 *The unisex script and the Final Girl*

Ripley exists because O'Bannon's screenplay declared its crew interchangeable between the sexes. Carol Clover's Final Girl — the resourceful, watchful survivor of the slasher film, onto whom male spectators displace their identification (Clover 1992) — is the nearest generic type, and Ripley is its limit case. She is not punished for desire, not coded as a child, and not defined by a killer's fixation; she is a warrant officer who reads procedures, invokes quarantine, and outlasts the Company's officers and its machines. Gallardo and Smith trace her construction across four films as the making of a new heroic type (Gallardo and Smith 2004), and Sigourney Weaver's Academy Award nomination for *Aliens* marked the type's rare entry into prestige. The Final Girl survives a killer. Ripley survives an economy.

§12.2 *Matricide and the Furies*

Luce Irigaray argued that Western culture rests on a matricide more archaic than the parricide Freud placed at its origin. Its charter is the *Oresteia*: Clytemnestra's murder is acquitted, her Furies are domesticated as honored guests beneath the city, and the mother's blood relation to her child is legally denied (Irigaray 1993 [1981]). The corpus replays the matricide incessantly, but from the mother's side. Ripley destroys the Queen; the Newborn kills its biological mother; the Offspring of *Romulus* feeds on the mother who bore it; Shaw aborts her monster; Ripley kills the queen embryo with herself and later kills the Newborn who calls her mother. Barbara Creed saw in the creature the return of the archaic mother that patriarchal culture must abject (Creed 1993). The Ripleyan lineage adds a complication Creed's model cannot absorb. Its heroines are mothers who must kill monstrous offspring, and daughters who must kill monstrous mothers, and the films ask that both acts be mourned. Kristeva's meditation on the Virgin who stands grieving at the cross (Kristeva 1985 [1977]) finds its secular counterpart in Ripley weeping at the Newborn's unbirth.

§12.3 *Natality against repetition*

Hannah Arendt made natality the central category of political thought: because each human being is born, each is a beginning, capable of initiating something unforeseen, and action is a kind of second birth (Arendt 1958). She closed her analysis of action by citing the "glad tidings" of the Gospel and Isaiah, "For unto us a child is born" (Isaiah 9:6, KJV), as the expression of faith in the world's renewal. Xenotokia is the precise negation of natality. The creature's births inaugurate nothing; each one reproduces the same form, consumes the host who might have begun something, and returns the cycle to its start. Freud's repetition compulsion, the drive to reproduce an earlier state even at the cost of pleasure (Freud 1920), is xenotokia's psychic form — and also, it must be said, the narrative form of a franchise that has staged the chestburst in nearly every installment.

Against repetition stands the Ripleyan act. Ripley's refusals — of the open hatch, of Burke's plan, of the Company's offer of children, of survival at the price of delivery — are beginnings in Arendt's sense: interruptions of an automatic process by an agent who could have done

otherwise. Natality, in the corpus, survives not as fertility but as the capacity to refuse.

§12.4 *Make kin, not babies*

Donna Haraway's slogan "Make Kin Not Babies!" proposes kinship by alliance and care across lines of species and descent, as an alternative to reproduction as the default form of futurity (Haraway 2016). Ripley's kin are exactly such a family: Jones the cat; Newt, adopted; Hicks, a soldier; Bishop, a synthetic; Call, an Auton; the Newborn, a hybrid. Rain's kinship with Andy is chosen against the Company's rewriting of it. Daniels, whose dream of a cabin by a lake dies with her husband, is the lineage's cautionary figure, a woman whose domestic future is foreclosed before she can choose another. Wendy's alliance with the creature extends kinship to the being the corpus had defined as kin's destroyer.

Haraway names her era the Chthulucene, and spells it to distance its tentacular, chthonic powers from Lovecraft's Cthulhu, whose cosmic horror she associates with misogyny and racism (Haraway 2016). The xenomorph stands exactly between the two chthonic imaginaries: Lovecraft's horror of the mixed, the deep, and the tentacled, and Haraway's affirmation of them. The corpus begins in the first and ends, tentatively, in the second.

§12.5 *Butler's counter-myth*

The single most important counter-text to the corpus is Octavia E. Butler's "Bloodchild" (1984). On a planet where human refugees live on a Preserve under the protection of the insectoid Tlic, young men carry Tlic eggs; the larvae must be removed surgically before they eat their way out. The story's narrator, Gan, witnesses such a removal from a man named Bram Lomas, in all its horror, and then chooses to carry T'Gatoi's eggs himself rather than let his sister do so. Butler insisted in her afterword that the story is not about slavery but is a love story and a story of a pregnant man, and that it began partly as a way of facing her horror of the botfly, whose larvae grow in living flesh (Butler 1995).

"Bloodchild" accepts every mark of xenotokia but one. The offspring is foreign; gestation risks the host's life; the Tlic depend on human bodies to reproduce. What is refused is effacement. Gan is addressed, ne-

gotiated with, given a choice, and offered in return an intimacy and a protection that bind host and parasite in obligation. Xenotokia is transformed into xenia: a hospitality of the flesh. Butler's *Xenogenesis* trilogy (1987–89) generalizes the transformation. Its heroine, Lilith Iyapo, wakes after a nuclear war on the ship of the Oankali, "gene traders" who survive by merging with other species, and becomes the mother of hybrid "constructs." Haraway read the trilogy as a biopolitics of postmodern bodies (Haraway 1991). The name Lilith, the infanticidal demon-mother of folklore (Chapter 3), is reclaimed for the first mother of a new kind. Where the corpus offers the Newborn torn apart through a breach, Butler offers a future that grows out of the breach.

§12.6 *Mary Shelley and the xenotokic origin of science fiction*

Brian Aldiss argued that science fiction begins with *Frankenstein* (Aldiss 1973). The genre's founding text was written by a woman whose mother, Mary Wollstonecraft, died of puerperal fever eleven days after giving birth to her in 1797. In 1815 Shelley's first child, a premature daughter, died within days, and she recorded a dream: "that my little baby came to life again; that it had only been cold, and that we rubbed it before the fire, and it lived" (*Journal*, 19 March 1815). Ellen Moers read *Frankenstein* as a "birth myth," a novel about the horror of creating life written by a young woman who had already lost a child (Moers 1976). In her 1831 introduction Shelley bade her "hideous progeny go forth and prosper."

The genre, then, was born from a birth that killed a mother and from a mother's dream of reviving a dead child by fire — a Promethean fire. Its first novel is subtitled *The Modern Prometheus*. When Scott names his prequel *Prometheus* and makes its villain a created son who becomes a creator, he returns science fiction to its founding wound. The corpus is not merely a franchise within the genre. It is the genre's most sustained meditation on the conditions of its own birth.

§12.7 *Amanda*

Alien: Isolation (2014) gives the lineage its reflexive form. Amanda Ripley, fifteen years after her mother's disappearance, travels to a decaying station in search of the *Nostromo*'s flight recorder. The daughter becomes the archivist of the mother: she seeks not a body but a record, and

must survive the creature to obtain it. *Aliens* had already told us that Amanda would die, aged sixty-six, before her mother was found. The game gives the abandoned child a story of her own and makes her quest the corpus's image of its readers — descendants searching the wreckage for the account of what happened to the women who refused.



13

The Theorem of the Host

Toward a General Xenotocology

The corpus proves a theorem: wherever generation is subsumed under self-valorizing value, it tends toward xenotokia, and the host becomes the decisive figure of the age. This chapter states the theorem formally, locates its historical archive, maps its field of possibilities on a semiotic square, defends it against rival readings, and turns it into a method.

§ 13.1 *The theorem stated*

Theorem. Where generation is subsumed under self-valorizing value, the bearing body becomes a host: its life is converted into an increment foreign to it, which returns as more of itself and presents itself as nurture.

Three lemmas support it, one from each register. *The biological lemma* (Chapter 2): mammalian generation already contains xenotokia in latent form — the fetus as allograft, the placenta as domesticated virus, the paternal genome as extractor — and is kept from manifest parasitism only by regulation, a negotiated hospitality of tolerance and counterpressure. Remove the regulation and the latent becomes manifest. *The economic lemma* (Aristotle, Marx): interest-bearing capital is xenotokia's social form, in which the borrower or worker gestates an increment that resembles the lender's money; "crew expendable" is its legal formula. *The cosmogonic lemma* (Chapters 3 and 8): in the corpus's mythology the

cosmos itself is generated by sacrificial dismemberment and seeded by makers who regard their creatures as stock; xenotokia is not an accident of creation but its mode.

Five corollaries follow. First, the Company and the creature are homologous, and the Company's desire for the creature is narcissistic: it wants an organism that reproduces as it does. Second, the gods are hosts — the fossilized pilot with his chest burst outward, the Engineer dissolving at the waterfall. Third, the only non-host, the synthetic, becomes either xenotokia's sovereign (David) or its redeemer (Bishop, Call, Andy). Fourth, natality survives not as fertility but as refusal and elective kinship. Fifth, the franchise, as interest-bearing property, is itself xenotokic, so that the theorem includes its own medium.

§13.2 *The historical archive:* partus sequitur ventrem

Xenotokia is not only a myth. It has a legal history, and its founding text is a Virginia statute of 1662, which declared that "all children borne in this country shalbe held bond or free only according to the condition of the mother." Its preamble names the situation it was written to govern: children fathered by Englishmen on enslaved African women. Its effect was to convert the products of sexual coercion into property and to make the enslaved womb a site of accumulation. Thomas Jefferson stated the arithmetic in a letter of 1820, judging a woman who bore a child every two years more profitable than the best laborer on the farm, because what she produced was "an addition to the capital" while his labor disappeared in consumption. Jennifer Morgan has shown that reproduction was the hinge on which racial capitalism turned (Morgan 2004; 2021).

Every mark of xenotokia is present. The child is legally foreign to its mother, belonging to another. Her body is the medium of the increment. The increment returns as more capital. Hortense Spillers describes the captive body reduced to "flesh," severed from will and kinship, its maternity converted into an instrument of property (Spillers 1987); her account is the most exact description of effacement in the scholarly literature. Patterson's natal alienation names the severed descent (Patterson 1982). And the institution presented itself, in pro-slavery ideology, as paternal care for a household "family" — dissimulation.

The corpus mythologizes xenotokia while displacing this archive. Its

archetypal host is a white woman; its creature is black, glistening, and sexually coded; its gods are white. The myth universalizes what history racialized, and in universalizing risks re-encoding the racial imaginary it abstracts from: the black body figured as the monstrous agent of reproduction rather than its expropriated subject. A xenotocology must name both the myth's insight and its displacement. The later installments begin, haltingly, to return the expropriated body to view — in the colonists stowed like cargo in *Covenant*, in the indentured miners and the reprogrammable brother of *Romulus*, in the children whose bodies are corporate property in *Alien: Earth* — without yet naming the history they echo.

§ 13.3 *The square of the host*

The corpus's field of possibilities can be mapped on a Greimasian semiotic square, the device A. J. Greimas devised to articulate a semantic opposition into its contraries, contradictories, and implications (Greimas 1966; Greimas and Rastier 1968), and that Jameson made an instrument for reading narrative as the imaginary resolution of real contradiction (Jameson 1981). The governing opposition is between two relations to the stranger. *Xenia* (S1) is reciprocal hospitality, in which host and guest bind each other without consumption. *Xenotokia* (S2) is parasitic generation, in which the stranger received consumes its host. Their contradictories are *hostility* (non-S1), the stranger as enemy — quarantine, flamethrower, Marines — and *fabrication* (non-S2), generation replaced by making, whose figure is the synthetic.

The combinations generate the corpus's positions. The complex term, S1 + S2, is *hostia*: hospitality that consents to be consumed — the Engineer at the waterfall, Janek's ramming, Ripley's fall, Gan in "Blood-child." The neutral term, non-S1 + non-S2, is *the Company*: neither hospitable nor generative in itself, it neither hosts nor bears but administers the generation of others and fabricates their tools. The left deixis, xenia + fabrication, is *kinship*: hospitality without generation, the elective families of Ripley, Newt, and Bishop or of Rain and Andy. The right deixis, xenotokia + hostility, is *the hive*: generation as war — the Queen, the bioweapon, Burke's plan, Giger's *Birth Machine*.

Each installment occupies or traverses a region. *Alien* (1979) discloses S2 against the neutral term (the creature and the Company, Ash

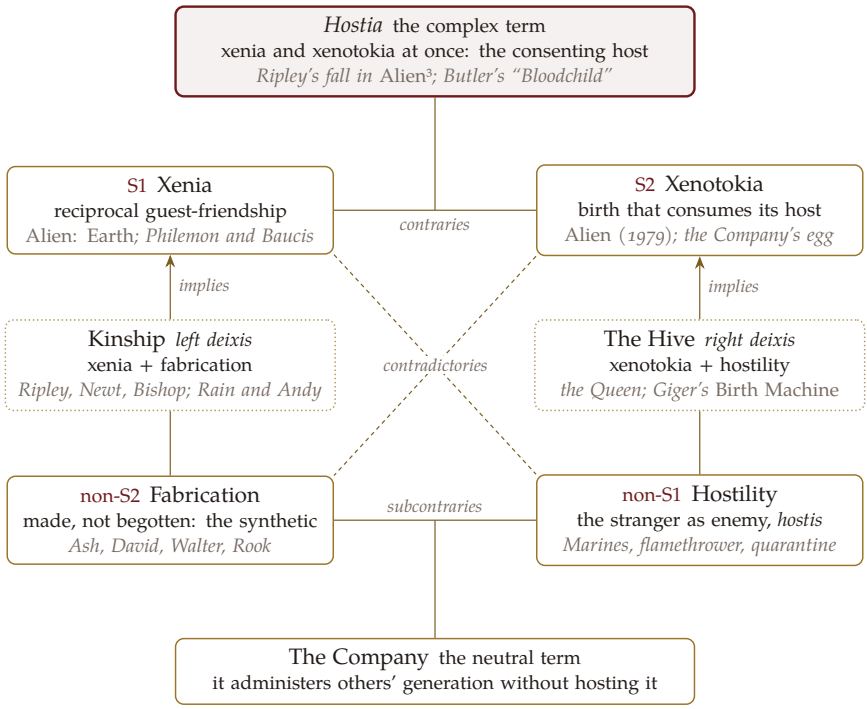


Figure 1. *The square of the host. Contraries run along the top edge and subcontraries along the bottom; the dashed diagonals join contradictories, and each upward arrow marks an implication that opens a deixis.*

between them). *Aliens* (1986) sets the two deixes at war, kinship against the hive. *Alien³* (1992) occupies the complex term. *Resurrection* (1997) strains toward S1 + S2 through the Newborn, kin born of xenotokia, and fails. The prequels (2012, 2017) pass from non-S2 to S2, fabrication becoming xenotokia in David. *Romulus* (2024) returns to the kinship deixis against the neutral term. *Alien: Earth* (2025) reaches S1 at last, and drifts at once toward sovereignty, the neutral term's mode of power.

§ 13.4 *Against allegorical inflation*

Criticism has read the creature as rape, the AIDS epidemic, the archaic mother, the Vietcong, colonial insurgency, and capital. The theorem explains why the allegories proliferate without exhausting it: every situation in which a body bears another's increment becomes legible through the creature, so the creature can be mistaken for each of its instances.

Noël Carroll's account of the monster as categorically interstitial, a fusion of what ought to be kept apart (Carroll 1990), describes its form; Mary Douglas's account of pollution as matter out of place, and of the Lele pangolin as an anomaly converted into sacred power through a cult that eats it (Douglas 1966), describes its function. The Company wants to eat the anomaly, to incorporate its power. Bataille's "accursed share," the excess every economy produces and must spend, gloriously or catastrophically (Bataille 1988 [1949]), describes its fate: the creature is the accursed share of accumulation, returning as catastrophe.

Schopenhauer supplies the deepest metaphysical gloss. He described the will-to-live as blind, insatiable striving that preys upon itself, citing the Australian bulldog ant, whose severed head and tail fight each other, and the turtles of Java devoured by wild dogs as they come ashore to lay their eggs (Schopenhauer 1966 [1818–44], §27; vol. 2, ch. 28). He called the genitals the focus of the will and the opposite pole to the brain (§60). Giger's skull — an eyeless, elongated, phallic dome, with a second mouth where a brain would be — is that inversion made anatomical: the head become genital, knowledge displaced by the will to reproduce. Peter Wessel Zapffe, who regarded consciousness as a tragic overendowment like the Irish elk's antlers (Zapffe 1933), would read Ash's envy of a creature without conscience as the envy of a being burdened with mind for one that is not. The antinatalist tradition that runs from Cioran (1973) to Benatar (2006) and Ligotti (2010) would draw the conclusion that birth is harm. The corpus refuses it. It never asks whether to be born, only whether to host. Its ethics are anti-xenotokic, not antinatalist, and its heroines are adoptive mothers, not abolitionists of birth.

§13.5 *Capital as xenomorph*

The theorem's economic face has been articulated, in celebratory form, by Nick Land, whose accelerationism figured capital as an inhuman intelligence assembling itself through human hosts (Land 2011). Mark Fisher, closer to the corpus's own sensibility, described capital as eerie: an agency where none should be, exerting more power than any substantial entity (Fisher 2016). Weber had already called the rationalized order a casing "hard as steel," the phrase Talcott Parsons rendered as the "iron cage" (Weber 1930 [1905]); Heidegger called the essence of mod-

ern technology an enframing that reveals everything, humans included, as standing-reserve, stock on call (Heidegger 1977 [1954]). The hypersleep pod is the human as standing-reserve, stored until the Company has a use for it.

The corpus agrees with Land's description and rejects his valuation. Land's admiration is Ash's, and Ash's head is burned. More precisely, the corpus discloses what Land omits: that the "autonomy" of a self-valorizing process is total dependence on hosts it does not acknowledge. The Company's pursuit of the creature, across six films and a series, is not mainly military. It is the pursuit of a self-portrait. The egg is Marx's golden egg, and the Company wants it because it recognizes its own face in a creature that has none.

§13.6 *The reflexive turn*

The fifth corollary returns the theorem to its medium. The franchise is xenotokic: each installment gestates inside its predecessor, feeds on its remembered body, and returns an increment that resembles the parent property. Callbacks are its eggs; the requel is its *tokos*; a dead actor's face can be made to host it. The critic is not exempt. This dissertation is a host as well, feeding on the corpus and returning an increment to the scholarly economy. The reflexivity is not a refutation of the theorem but a confirmation: a myth that thinks capital must be produced by capital, and it can think it only from inside.

§13.7 *Xenotocology as method*

Xenotocology names the reading practice the theorem makes possible: an interrogation of any text, institution, or practice for its implicit theory of the host. It asks seven questions.

1. Who is the host, and who chose them?
2. What is consumed in the bearing, and what is left?
3. What returns as surplus, and whom does it resemble?
4. Whose face is effaced, and at what point can they no longer refuse?
5. What nurture dissimulates the extraction?
6. Where is the refusal, and what does it cost?
7. Where is the xenia — the reciprocal relation in which neither party is consumed — and what institution could make it last?

The method extends beyond the corpus. It applies to transnational commercial surrogacy, which Amrita Pande has studied as a form of reproductive labor (Pande 2014); to markets in organs and tissues; to platform labor whose workers carry the risks of an enterprise that owns the returns; and to extractive ecologies in which a planet is treated as the host of an economy that will not acknowledge it. In each case the questions are the same, and the corpus's answer is the same: the only response to xenotokia that does not become another form of it is a hospitality that refuses to be consumed and refuses to consume.



Conclusion

From the Chestburster to the Open Door

The corpus begins with a door that must not be opened and ends, forty-six years later, with a cell door closing on the makers. Between those two doors it has taught its audience to see the host everywhere — in the crew, the colonist, the prisoner, the clone, the worker, the child — and it has not yet learned how to be one. That incompletion is not a failure of the myth. It is the form in which the myth hands its question to the present.

The oldest host in this dissertation's archive is the couple who opened their door. Ovid's Philemon and Baucis received two strangers whom a thousand households had refused, served them from their poverty, and were spared when their neighbors drowned; their reward was to die together and stand as intertwined trees before the temple their cottage had become. Goethe gave them a second life and a second death. In the fifth act of *Faust*, Part Two, the old couple's cottage and chapel stand in the way of Faust's great project of land reclamation, and at his order Mephistopheles' men burn them out. Marshall Berman read the scene as the founding image of modernity's "tragedy of development": the first casualties of the developer are the hosts of the gods (Berman 1982). The *Alien* corpus is that tragedy extended to the scale of a cosmos. Its Company is Faust without remorse, its colonies are reclaimed land, and its creature is the shape the development takes when it no longer needs a developer.

Derrida distinguished the conditional laws of hospitality — rights, duties, papers, quarantine — from an unconditional Law that would

welcome the arrivant without asking its name, and held the second to be both impossible and necessary: impossible because it would abolish the host who welcomes, necessary because without it the laws of hospitality decay into the policing of strangers (Derrida and Dufourmantelle 1997). The corpus dramatizes both decays. Unconditional welcome admits the parasite: Ash opens the hatch. Conditional welcome becomes extermination or a cage: the flamethrower in the egg chamber, the specimen cells of Neverland turned on their keepers. *Alien: Earth*'s final image leaves the aporia exactly where Derrida left it. Wendy's alliance with the creature is the first xenia the corpus has imagined, and its first act is to imprison. Whether it will become a new hospitality or a new sovereignty is the question with which the myth, for now, ends.

Octavia Butler suggests a third path, which the corpus has not taken. Gan's choice in "Bloodchild" is neither the unconditional welcome that admits a consumer nor the conditional refusal that ends in fire. It is a negotiated hospitality of the flesh, entered by consent, conducted face to face, asymmetrical and acknowledged as such, in which the host can speak, the guest must answer, and both are bound. Such a hospitality does not abolish the stranger's strangeness or the host's risk. It refuses only effacement. That refusal is the minimal condition of any relation to the alien that is not xenotokia, and it is the one condition the Company can never meet, because its form of life depends on hosts without faces.

The Gnostic "Hymn of the Pearl," read in Chapter 4 as the inverted template of the 1979 film, ends with a return the corpus has not yet written. The prince, pearl in hand, comes home and is given back his robe; looking at it, he sees himself in it as in a mirror, and recognizes that he and it are two and yet one. The corpus's pearl remains a serpent, and its heroes come home, when they come home at all, as strangers. But the image of the robe — the self encountered as another and recognized without being consumed — is the image toward which the corpus's later installments grope: Ripley mourning the Newborn, Rain restoring Andy's chip, Wendy listening to the creature. Arendt called natality the miracle that saves the world from its own ruin, because every birth can begin something new (Arendt 1958). In a world organized by xenotokia, the corpus suggests, the miracle takes a different form. It is not the birth of a child but the birth of a relation: a hospitality that refuses to be consumed and refuses to consume.

The question the corpus bequeaths is therefore not how to kill the alien. Six films and a series have answered that, and the answer has always come back as a sequel. The question is how to be a host without becoming a hostage, a hostile, or a *hostia* — how to be, in the last words Ripley speaks in the corpus, a stranger here oneself.

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Keywords

xenotokia; xenotocology; hospitality (*xenia*); hostipitality; host / *hostis* / *hostia*; *tokos* and usury; *Alien* franchise; science-fiction cinema; horror film; body horror; parasitism and parasitoids; maternal–fetal conflict; monstrous-feminine; abjection; Final Girl; reproductive futurism; natality; elective kinship; companion species; synthetic personhood; posthumanism; Gnosticism; demiurgy; political theology; Nicene Christology; Greimasian semiotic square; structural anthropology; myth criticism; critical political economy; automatic subject; necropolitics; racial capitalism; *partus sequitur ventrem*; Black feminist theory; cosmic horror; biomechanics (H. R. Giger); Prometheus myth; Mary Shelley; Octavia E. Butler; the face (Levinas); hospitality (Derrida); lamella (Lacan); hauntology; franchise studies; intellectual property